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THE ECONOMIC TIMES

BENNETT, COLEMAN & CO. LTD. | ESTD. 1838 | VOL. 42 NO. 176 | BENGALURU | 10 PAGES | ₹10 ONLY | SATURDAY, 25 JULY 2026

Qcomm will Keep Drawing Capital, says Swiggy CEO
COMPANIES: PURSUIT OF PROFIT ▸▸ 5

Private Sector Growth Cools to 4-Yr Low in July
ECONOMY: MACRO, MICRO & MORE ▸▸ 4

Commonwealth Games Kick Off in Glasgow
SPORTS: WORLD PLAY ▸▸ 10

NO TARIFF RATE QUOTA EXEMPTION A CONCERN FOR TEXTILE INDUSTRY

US Slaps 10% Duty on India After Forced Labour Probe

Sec 301 levies replace temporary 10% tariffs, no change in overall burden

Our Bureau

New Delhi: The US has levied 10% tariffs on goods purchased from India and 16 other countries over what it described as their failure to impose bans on imports made with forced labour.

The duty is lower than the 12.5% tariff the US proposed in June as part of a broader probe under Section 301 of its Trade Act. Pakistan, Bangladesh, Cambodia, Sri Lanka, and the UK have also been slapped with 10% tariffs.

However, India didn't get textile and apparel tariff-rate quota (TRQ) exemption, which applies to specified volumes of textile and apparel exports from Bangladesh, Cambodia, Indonesia, and Malaysia that use US-origin cotton and fibre. Indian exporters said they are concerned by Washington's decision.

The latest tariffs replace the temporary 10% duty introduced by US President Donald Trump earlier this year, which expired at midnight.

For most Indian exporters, the overall tariff burden will remain broadly unchanged, as they would continue to face an additional 10% over and above the applicable most favoured nation (MFN) tariff, exporters said.

"We had expected higher tariffs and this differential will be advantageous in certain sectors," said an exporter.

Trade Pangs

India among 17 countries slapped with 10% tariffs

Move after it banned imports made with forced labour

43 other economies face 12.5% duty

India out of textile tariff rate quota mechanism

MFN tariffs and 10% Sec 301 duty apply to about 70% of country's exports to US

Goods under Sec 232 still face 25-50% levies along with MFN duty

SEC 301 TARIFFS (%)

Pak	10
Bangladesh	10
UK	10
China	12.5
Vietnam	12.5

Sourcing Decisions ▸▸ 8

SEE ALSO ▸▸ 4

Nifty Settles below Support Level of 23,800

Indian equities fell as much as 1.2% before recovering on Friday, as a spike in crude oil prices and depreciation in the rupee kept investors on edge. The Nifty's closing below a key support level of 23,800 has raised likelihood of more declines. Sensex and Nifty fell 2.3% for the week. ▸▸ 8

Brent Crude Eases after Topping $100

Brent crude retreated after hitting $100 a barrel amid concerns over the economic impact of high prices and renewed US tariffs, yet remained set for a substantial weekly surge amid hostilities in West Asia. It dropped to $95.61 barrel on Friday.

Re hits Intraday Low, Rebounds after RBI Action

RBI action Friday ensured that rupee did not weaken beyond its record low of 96.96, dealers said. The unit hit an intraday low of 96.70/dollar, before recovering to close at 96.562, changing little its previous close of 96.565. ▸▸ 8

PM EYES YOUTH CONNECT VIA INSTAGRAM

Cabinet Clears Stricter Bill on Paper Leaks

Up to 10-yr jail, ₹10cr fine mooted; CJP sticks to Pradhan's resignation demand

IANS

Union ministers JP Nadda & Jitendra Singh with CJP leaders

Jatin Takkar

New Delhi: The cabinet led by Prime Minister Narendra Modi approved a bill proposing stricter punishment for paper leaks, including fine up to ₹10 crore.

Meanwhile, two senior Union ministers held talks with Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) leaders a few kilometres away, underscoring the Centre's parallel legislative and political push to defuse the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (NEET) examination paper leak agitation that has rocked the national capital and found echoes across the country. Both sides have agreed to meet again on Saturday.

Chaired by Prime Minister Modi at Parliament House, the cabinet approved amendments to the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024, proposing a minimum five-year jail term for those involved in paper leaks and up to 10 years' imprisonment with a maximum fine of ₹10 crore for organised paper leak syndicates.

Other Measures for Students ▸▸ 8

SPECIAL TASK FORCE SET UP FOR INVESTIGATION

NTA Terminates 47 Officials

NTA on Friday terminated around 47 officials, even as Delhi Police announced formation of a special task force to probe paper leaks. ▸▸ 2

RELATED REPORTS ▸▸ 2

PURE POLITICS

SC Proposes Special Courts for Manipur Violence Cases

The Apex Court Friday indicated that it plans to constitute special courts for day-to-day trial of cases connected to the ethnic violence in Manipur and directed investigating agencies to expedite pending investigations and asked the state to extend cooperation. ▸▸ 3

Flood Fears Grip J&K, Trucks Stranded on Highway ▸▸ 3

Assam Toll Rises to 47, CM Flags 'Unusual' Flooding

Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma said 47 people have died and eight are missing in the current wave of floods. Heavy rainfall in Nagaland's Mokokchung, Wokha and Mon districts, along with Charaideo in Assam, between July 18 -20 triggered the flood. **Bikash Singh** reports. ▸▸ 3

Adani Says Want to Start Airline, Shows Letter

But group denies plans in a stock exchange filing

GMR AIRPORTS* Delhi, Hyderabad, Goa, Nagpur

ADANI AIRPORTS Mumbai, Navi Mumbai, Ahmedabad, Lucknow, Jaipur, Guwahati, Trivandrum

PASSENGER FOOTFALL SHARE: 27.2% | 23%

*GMR group will also operate the Bhogapuram Airport near Vizag

Arindam Majumder

New Delhi: The Adani Group is uniquely positioned to support the development of a next-generation airline, the conglomerate's airport arm wrote to the Airports Authority of India (AAI) in June.

In its letter that **ET** has reviewed, Adani Airport Holdings sought a waiver of the clause that prevents the operator of Mumbai's airport from holding more than a 10% stake in any scheduled carrier, and the removal of such restrictions from future airport concession agreements.

The conglomerate, which owns a 74% stake in the Mumbai airport, however, said on Friday that it is "not evaluating any proposal to enter the airline business". Adani Enterprises, the main holding company of the group, in a stock exchange filing termed such media reports "entirely baseless and factually incorrect".

In the letter dated June 4, Adani Airports chief executive Arun Bansal said group firm Adani Defence & Aerospace was evaluating starting an airline as a natural extension of the group's existing aviation ecosystem.

Bridging Connectivity ▸▸ 8

RJ Group Picks Ex-Diageo Maven Mishra to Expand Drinks Play

Ravi Jaipuria-owned RJ Corp group, PepsiCo's bottler for three decades, has tapped former Diageo executive Prathmesh Mishra to likely help expand the group's beverages footprint into premium alcoholic drinks, people aware of the high-profile hire told ET. Spirits volumes climbed about 4% in FY26. ▸▸ 7

Sebi Cracks Down on Axis Mutual Fund Front-Running Ring

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) on Friday imposed penalties totalling ₹7.5 crore on former Axis Mutual Fund chief dealer Viresh Joshi and 20 others after concluding that they carried out a front-running scheme that generated illegal gains by trading ahead of the fund house's orders. ▸▸ 8

More Banks Likely to Join Bond Rally After ICICI Bank Bond Sale

ICICI Bank's successful inaugural dollar bond sale, marked by strong investor appetite and low interest rate, is expected to encourage more domestic lenders to tap overseas debt markets in the coming weeks as lenders seek to lock in competitive funding costs amid sustained demand for Indian financial paper. ▸▸ 8

CORPORATE SCORECARD

Hindustan Zinc Net Profit Surges 145%

Hindustan Zinc's net profit jumped 145% to ₹5,469 crore in the June quarter driven by s ilver which is poised to emerge as the single-biggest growth engine over the next four to five years, said CEO Arun Misra. **Nikita Periwal** reports.

Tata Consumer Profit Flat, may Hike Prices

Tata Consumer posted a 14% YoY rise in revenue from operations to ₹4,028.3 crore in the June quarter, while net profit was largely unchanged at ₹714.3 crore. The company is likely to raise prices, its MD and CEO Sunil D'Souza said.

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TRANSACTION VALUES NUTRACEUTICAL CO AT $900M

Pep Pill: Bain Capital to Buy UK's Vitabiotics

Besides UK business, deal will also include VB Group, comprising Meyer Organics in India and ops in Africa

Our Bureau

Mumbai: Private equity firm Bain Capital will acquire Vitabiotics, UK's leading nutraceutical company, bolstering its presence in the expanding global market for nutrition, vitamins, minerals, and wellness supplements. The deal will encompass the entire enterprise, including the UK business and the wider VB Group, comprising Meyer Organics in India, and operations in Africa, including VB Egypt.

The deal size wasn't disclosed. The transaction valued Vitabiotics at $850-900 million, said people familiar with the matter.

ET was the first to report April 21 about Bain Capital emerging as the frontrunner for Vitabiotics. Two other contenders TPG Capital and EQT opted out of the competitive bidding process, ET had reported.

ET was first to report on April 21 about Bain Capital emerging as the frontrunner for Vitabiotics

Founded in 1971 by Kartar Lalvani, a British-Indian businessman, Vitabiotics is currently led by his son, Tej Lalvani — also known for his role as an investor on BBC's Dragon's Den — who serves as chief executive officer. Its portfolio of brands includes Pregnacare, Perfectil, Wellman, Wellwoman, Osteocare, and the Ultra range.

The NRI founders have been seeking a valuation of around £900 million ($1-1.2 billion). However, waning competitive interest is likely to impact the final price, ET had reported.

No Immediate Changes to Ops ▸▸ 8

FRENCH INSURER TO BUY WARBURG STAKE IN INDIAFIRST LIFE

BNP Paribas Cardif to Re-enter India

BNP Paribas Cardif has agreed to acquire Warburg Pincus' 25.96% stake in IndiaFirst Life Insurance, marking the French insurer's re-entry into India's life insurance market after nearly five years.

FMCG Cos Get Online Shopping Rewards

Revenue from digital-first brands acquired by legacy players growing fast

Aanya Thakur

Mumbai: The bet's paying off for India's big consumer goods companies that have acquired digital-first brands, with some of them becoming fastest-growing divisions of their parents in terms of sales. They generated more than ₹2,000 crore in combined revenue in FY26, up over 20% from a year earlier, according to an **ET** analysis. These include brands such as Minimalist, Oziva, Beardo, Yoga Bar, Mother Sparsh, Plix, True Elements, Cosmix and 4700BC.

Marico's acquired portfolio accounted for more than 11% of FY26 revenue, while Hindustan Unilever's Minimalist and Oziva contributed around 1.6% of revenue. Godrej Consumer's men's care brand Muuchstac currently constitutes 0.2% of its total revenue.

"We're happy with the growth of these brands because we are profitable. Beardo has already hit double-digit profitability and Plix is expecting it soon," Marico MD and chief executive Saugata Gupta told ET recently. "We would prefer profitable growth over cash-burning expansion."

Marico Aggressive Buyer ▸▸ 8

Adding More to Cart

D2C subsidiary ● FY26 revenue (₹cr)

HUL		MARICO		GCPL
Minimalist 551	Oziva 462	Plix 839	Beardo 299	Muuchstac 29.5

Share of digital-first brands in overall FY26 revenue (%)

MARICO	11.0
HUL	1.6
GCPL	0.2

ITC: **Acquired brands:** Yogabar, Mother Sparsh, Prasuma and 24 Mantra | **Portfolio crossed an annual revenue run rate of ₹1,350 crore in FY26**

AS STUDENTS PROTEST OVER NEET-UG PAPER LEAK

NTA Sacks 47 Officials; Delhi Police Sets up STF

Legal, criminal action to be initiated against some of these officials

Our Political Bureau

REPRESENTATIONAL PHOTO

New Delhi: Amid ongoing student protests over the NEET-UG leak controversy, the National Testing Agency (NTA) on Friday terminated around 47 officials, with "more cleanup to follow", even as Delhi Police announced the formation of an STF to investigate paper leaks.

Legal and criminal action will also be initiated against some of these officials, and more reform measures will follow, sources in the know said, adding that this is part of a "complete overhaul" of the NTA. The NTA has been in the eye of the storm over the leak of the May 3 NEET-UG question paper and the subsequent cancellation of the exam, followed by a re-examination on June 26, an exercise involving over 22 lakh students.

The CBI's investigation has so far pointed to the involvement of NTA-empanelled translators from Maharashtra in the paper leak.

Later in the evening, Delhi Police announced the setting up of a Special Task Force (STF) under the Crime Branch to investigate paper leaks and examination-related offences under the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024. The STF will probe cases related to examinations conducted by agencies, including the UPSC, SSC, RRBs, IBPS, NTA and other notified authorities. It will also coordinate with prosecuting agencies to ensure speedy trials.

STF PROBE

STF will probe cases related to examinations conducted by agencies, including the UPSC, SSC, RRBs, IBPS, NTA & others

The STF will further probe examinations conducted by ministries and departments of the central government, as well as their attached and subordinate offices, for staff recruitment. It will also cover exams conducted by any other authority notified by the central government from time to time, according to Delhi Police.

In addition to investigations, the STF will ensure effective coordination with prosecuting agencies to facilitate expeditious prosecution and ensure that trials in such cases are conducted on a day-to-day basis.

The STF will be headed by Deputy Commissioner of Police, Crime Branch, Delhi Police. The Special Commissioner of Police, Crime Branch, will exercise overall supervision and administrative control over functioning of the STF and issue necessary directions to ensure effective investigation and diligent prosecution of cases, according to Delhi Police.

PROTESTS IN DELHI

SC to Hear Plea on Police Action Against Students on Monday

SC bars circulating, posting clips of live-streamed court hearings without prior permission

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: The Supreme Court on Friday agreed to hear on July 27 a plea alleging police excesses against students protesting at Jantar Mantar. The matter was mentioned before a three-member bench headed by CJI Surya Kant.

Appearing on behalf of the petitioner, senior advocate Gopal Sankaranarayanan submitted that a petition had been filed. "There is urgency. Police excess is going against students. Something has to be done... the court is standing in between," the senior lawyer submitted. Speaking for the bench, CJI Kant said that the bench will take up the plea on Monday.

What I never said was thrust upon me. It was a representation and people recklessly reported it: CJI

Earlier in the day, CJI Kant took exception to what he described as "false reporting" by media over his recent remarks made in connection with a mentioning made by a lawyer earlier this week about the protests led by CJP in Delhi. "What I never said was thrust upon me," CJI Kant remarked. Elaborating, he added that on Wednesday a lawyer mentioned the case. "It was only a representation and people started recklessly reporting it. I checked with registry. Not a paper was filed... only a mentioning was made before me. Till today no petition has been filed. Can an application sent to Registrar General be taken up for hearing?" CJI Kant remarked.

In an unrelated development, the SC passed an interim order prohibiting the unauthorised use or circulation of live-streamed court proceedings on social media and other digital platforms without prior permission. The SC made it clear that the order will not affect news reporting. "This is not a gag order on the press," the bench comprising CJI Kant, Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana clarified.

TO BOLSTER SECURITY AS PROTESTS CONTINUE

Centre Airlifts 10 More CRPF Companies to Delhi

Our Political Bureau

PTI

New Delhi: Ten Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) companies were airlifted from Chhattisgarh on Friday to be deployed in Delhi to bolster security measures in view of the continuing student protest, officials said. Thousands of students and activists have been protesting in the national capital for more than a month, demanding Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation over serial examination paper leaks including the medical college entrance test.

Separately, the Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) restricted leaves of its Delhi Metro security unit due to the protests.

A security review meeting held on Thursday decided that all CAPF units scheduled to be stationed in the capital ahead of Independence Day be asked to report early. About 150 CAPF companies will be deployed in Delhi over the next few days, with each company comprising about 100 personnel, according to the officials. About 100 such companies are already in Delhi assisting the local police with law and order duties, they said.

Earlier this week, the Centre airlifted 20 CRPF companies from West Bengal to be deployed in Delhi to oversee student protests being waged under the banner of the Cockroach Janta Party. Close on its heels came the induction of three Rapid Action Force units and several other CAPF units, such as the SSB, BSF and ITBP.

CISF RESTRICTS LEAVES

Central Industrial Security Force has restricted leaves of its Delhi Metro security unit due to the ongoing student protests

CISF officials said orders have been issued to sanction only emergency leaves to its Delhi Metro unit as maximum manpower is required at the metro stations given the security situation in Delhi-National Capital Region. The CISF has deployed about 13,000 personnel to provide counter-terrorism security cover across 250 stations of the rapid rail network in the National Capital Region.

Union Minister Bittu Resigns, To Shift Focus to Punjab

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: Union Minister of State for Railways and Food Processing Industries Ravneet Singh Bittu on Friday resigned from the Union Council of Ministers. Bittu was a Rajya Sabha member and his term ended in June. He continued to be a minister without being a member of any of the houses.

The BJP is planning to field Ravneet Singh Bittu from an assembly constituency in Ludhiana

Bittu's resignation has been accepted by the President of India Droupadi Murmu. Before Bittu, former Union minister of state George Kurian had also resigned in June after his Rajya Sabha term came to an end.

BJP sources told **ET** that Bittu will now play a bigger role in the upcoming Punjab assembly elections and the party is planning to field him from one of the assembly seats in Ludhiana.

AD HOC ARRANGEMENTS NO SUBSTITUTE: APEX COURT

SC Asks Govt to Spell Out CBT Plan, Pushes NEET Reform

Asks Centre to file comprehensive reply to prevent future leaks

Raghav Ohri

New Delhi: The Supreme Court on Friday made it clear that it would push for systemic reforms rather than short-term measures to safeguard the integrity of the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (NEET). A division bench of justices PS Narasimha and Alok Aradhe said it will "focus on institutionalisation", adding that "adhocism is what has troubled all these years".

The bench also said it will monitor the matter throughout the year. "We will take that extra mile to ensure that things are put in place," Justice Narasimha verbally remarked. In response, solicitor general Tushar Mehta assured the bench that the "government is going ten extra miles. Children's problems have to be addressed. Everything is being done under the supervision of the highest executive level".

He sought time to file the Centre's counter-affidavit, adding that there was "some development in the offing". He said the government was taking a "holistic view" of systemic changes to safeguard the integrity of the NEET examination.

The solicitor general also indicated that the government had accepted reforms recommended by a high-level committee set up in 2024 to review the functioning of the NTA after the alleged leak of the NEET-UG 2024 paper. The bench reiterated that ad hoc arrangements were no substitute for permanent reforms. "We are focusing on institutionalisation…this year because of what happened you had deployed the air force to transport (the exam papers). But that's only an ad hoc situation. There must be something permanent," Justice Narasimha said. "We can't let it go on like this," the bench added, before adjourning the matter till next week to allow the Centre to file its detailed counter-affidavit.

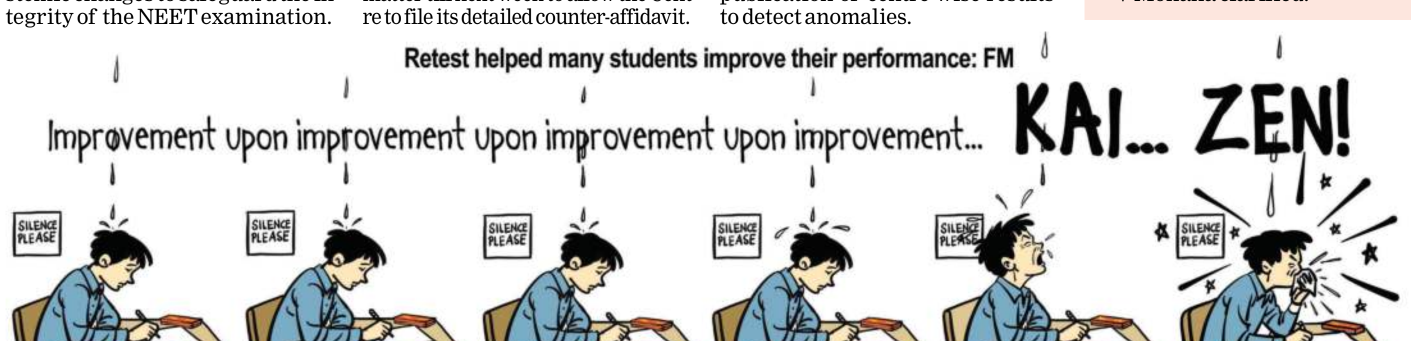
HOLISTIC VIEW

Govt taking a 'holistic view' of systemic changes to safeguard the integrity of the NEET exam: Solicitor General

The bench also sought the Centre's response on transitioning NEET to a computer-based test (CBT). "Another important aspect the (Radhakrishnan) committee had suggested was transition to computer-based testing. Please tell us what the thought is on that. Who is to undertake (the cybersecurity)? How is it to be conducted, etc.? How is the data to be protected? Data safety is the most important aspect," Justice Narasimha said.

The court asked the Centre to file a comprehensive response covering measures to prevent future paper leaks and its position on shifting NEET to a computer-based format. It urged the government to submit its counter-affidavit "as early as possible".

The observations came during the resumed hearing of a batch of petitions, including one filed by the Federation of All India Medical Association (FAIMA), which has sought restructuring of the NTA. Among other measures, the petition sought "digital locking" of question papers, a transition to a computer-based test model and publication of centre-wise results to detect anomalies.



RIJIJU URGES DEBATE; RAHUL DEMANDS PRADHAN'S EXIT

LS Logjam Enters Day 5 as Govt, Oppn Stick to Their Guns

PTI

Rahul slams govt over alleged use of pellet guns against agitating students

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: Work in the Lok Sabha was disrupted for the fifth consecutive day on Friday as Opposition MPs remained firm on their demand for Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation over the paper leak issue even as Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju renewed his appeal to Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi to persuade the Congress to agree to a discussion on the issue in the House. Later, Gandhi slammed the government, especially over the alleged use of pellet guns by police against protesting students.

In his appeal in the House, Rijiju claimed that some Opposition MPs were also keen to resume normal work and urged Gandhi to reconsider the Congress' stand. After the House was adjourned, Gandhi told reporters that the government had denied him an opportunity to respond to Rijiju. He reiterated the party's demand that Pradhan must first resign before any discussion on the paper leak issue could take place in the House.

Congress MP brought a student who suffered eye injury as cops allegedly used pellet guns against protesters

Later, Gandhi brought before the public a student who had reportedly suffered an eye injury after police allegedly used pellet guns to disperse the agitating students. "The pellet gun was used when my brother was holding the Indian tricolour and protesting peacefully. The government has said no pellet guns were used. See this, this is a pellet gun. His eye has been damaged; he has lost his vision," Gandhi said.

IN RAJYA SABHA

Govt Moves Bill to Criminalise Insults to Vande Mataram

Upper House fails to function, to meet on Monday

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: The government on Friday introduced a bill in the Rajya Sabha to make any obstruction or insult to the national song, Vande Mataram, a criminal offence. Minister of State for Home Affairs Nityanand Rai introduced The Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026, amid protests by Opposition members.

Union min Rai tabled 'The Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026'

The bill seeks to amend the Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act, 1971, which makes desecration of or disrespect towards the country's national symbols, including the national flag, the Constitution and the national anthem, a criminal offence punishable with imprisonment of up to three years.

Earlier in the day, Rajya Sabha failed to function on last day of the first week of the Monsoon Session, resulting in a complete washout of the week. The Upper House will now meet on Monday.

Talks Progress; Centre, CJP to Meet Again

Education minister's resignation not under consideration, government sources indicate

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: The Centre's engagement with Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) to resolve the NEET paper leak agitation gathered pace on Friday, with the two sides holding their third round of talks and agreeing to meet again on Saturday. However, the negotiations remain deadlocked over the CJP's demand for education minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation.

Calling Pradhan's resignation "non-negotiable", CJP leaders said they conveyed to Union ministers J P Nadda and Jitendra Singh that the agitation would continue until the demand was met. Government sources, however, indicated that Pradhan's resignation was not under consideration, suggesting the talks would instead focus on addressing the protesters' other demands. Besides Pradhan's resignation, the CJP sought a public apology to students allegedly assaulted during the July 20 march to Parliament, Rs 1 crore compensation for families of students who died by suicide following the cancellation of the May 3 NEET examination, and withdrawal of FIRs against protesters.

The two-hour meeting at Vithalbhai Patel House was aimed at finding an amicable solution to the protests. "We told Union ministers that our demand for the resignation of Pradhan is non-negotiable," CJP spokesperson Saurav Das said after the meeting. He added that the government had responded positively to the demands relating to compensation and withdrawal of cases against protesters. Nadda said the ministers had heard the CJP's demands and would respond after internal consultations. "We will meet again on Saturday," he said.

Happy that Wangchuk Ended his Fast: Tankha

New Delhi: Congress Parliamentarian Vivek Tankha, who was part of a group of Opposition MPs who visited Sonam Wangchuk in hospital urging him to end his hunger strike, on Friday expressed happiness about the activist finally calling off his fast after talks with the government. Tankha, a friend and lawyer of Wangchuk, also pointed out 19 Opposition MPs, including him, had also written a joint letter to the activist, urging him to end his fast.

"I am happy Wangchuk finally ended his hunger strike. As a friend of his, and as part of a group of Opposition MPs, I was in touch with Wangchuk, urging him to end his fast. On its part, the government was also making its own efforts. I am glad he ended his hunger strike because I want him to live. At the same time the students' agitation will continue even after he ends his fast," Tankha said. — OPB

'NOT STOPPING OUR FIGHT JUST BECAUSE SOME FEEL UNEASY ABOUT IT'

Selja Slams Wangchuk's Wife, Asks Why Target Cong & Not Modi Govt?

CL Manoj

New Delhi: Congress general secretary Kumari Selja on Friday questioned activist Sonam Wangchuk's wife, Gitanjali J Angmo, a day after the latter had said that the Rahul Gandhi-led Congress demonstration near the Prime Minister's residence against paper leaks "lacked sincerity" and that the principal Opposition should have instead joined the CJP protest at Jantar Mantar.

Selja asked why Angmo chose to target Gandhi and Congress rather than the government. "Why are they training their guns at Rahul Gandhi and Congress instead of attacking the Modi government? What does it smack of? In any case, Sonam Wangchuk has already ended his hunger strike after discussions with the government's representatives," Selja told **ET** when asked about Angmo's comments in a TV interview about the Congress demonstration.

Selja, a member of Congress Working Committee, also questioned the logic of Angmo stating that the Congress leaders should have protested at Jantar Mantar instead of outside the PM's residence. "Why so? Indian democracy offers the right and space for everyone to dissent and protest, by choosing their own respective space and methods. Congress party has been fighting for safeguarding this democratic right as much as we are now fighting against the Modi government over the series of paper leaks and in support of the agitating students," she said.

She further said, "We respect others' protests on the issue. Why should some people, who are also conducting their own protests, now feel so offended by Congress protest? I can understand why the Modi government and BJP are feeling uneasy about Congress protest, but why should some among the protestors feel the same way? By the way, some of our party colleagues had earlier visited Jantar Mantar."

Selja also stressed on Rahul Gandhi's role in the protest. "Everybody knows Rahulji has been at the forefront of fighting the government over paper leaks and taking up the students' causes by conducting 'Chhatron ki Goonj' rallies. The NSUI (Congress' student wing) activists are agitating against paper leaks across the nation. We are not going to stop our fight just because some others are feeling uneasy about it," she said.

Angmo's comments followed Arvind Kejriwal-led AAP's criticism of Congress protest near the PM's residence.

Poliloquy R PRASAD

He realised it was an exercise in futility. Rahul was gaining all the weight Sonam was losing!

This newspaper is published by Manjeet Singh Dhami from Bennett Coleman & Co Ltd., Elixir Chancery Building, 1st, 2nd and 4th Floor, 135, Residency Road, Shanthala Nagar, Bengaluru – 560025 (Phones: Office: EPABX - 080- 42200000, Editorial: 080- 46787878) on behalf of Bennett Coleman & Co Ltd., edited by Manu P Toms and printed by Sekar S at Bennett Coleman & Co Ltd., The Times of India Press, No. 9/10/11-A, 4th Main, KIADB Bommasandra Industrial Area, Anekal Taluk, Bangalore - 560 099 (Ph: 080-22899999). Regd office: Dr. D.N. Road, Mumbai - 400 001. All rights reserved. Reproduction in whole or in part without written permission is prohibited. REGD. NO. CPMG/KA/GPO-31/20C3-05, RNI NO. 45467/85

MAY HOST INDIA EDITION OF CHANGENOW TOO

Tech Summit Plans Electronics, Semicon Track for 2026

Initiative aims to bring together cos, policymakers and industry stakeholders across the electronics and semiconductor value chain

Our Bureau

Bengaluru: Bengaluru Tech Summit plans to add a dedicated conference track and exhibition pavilion for electronics and semiconductors at its 29th edition, scheduled for November 17-19.

The state announced the initiative at an event where chief minister DK Shivakumar unveiled the 29th edition of the summit, themed "AI and Beyond."

"One of Karnataka's greatest strengths has been the trust and partnership we have built with industry. We want to build a globally connected innovation ecosystem that drives technological leadership, entrepreneurship and inclusive growth," IT/BT minister Priyank Kharge said in a statement.

AS I WAS SAYING... Karnataka home minister Priyank Kharge interacts with Infosys cofounder Kris Gopalakrishnan, in Bengaluru on Friday. — PTI

The electronics and semiconductor track forms part of the inaugural India edition of embedded world India, organised in partnership with Germany-based trade fair organiser NuernbergMesse India.

The initiative aims to bring together companies, policymakers and industry stakeholders across the electronics and semiconductor value chain, the statement said.

The summit also plans to host the India edition of Changenow, a France-based platform focused on environmental and social innovation.

The Karnataka government expects the summit to attract more than 1,800 exhibitors, 25,000 delegates, 1,000 startups and over 60,000 business visitors from 75 countries and 30 states and Union Territories. The conference agenda includes tracks on artificial intelligence, deeptech, fintech, biotechnology, spacetech, electronics and semiconductors, digital infrastructure, data centres and electric mobility. The event also plans startup showcases, investor meetings and mentoring sessions under its Future Makers programme.

FUTURE FORWARD

CM DK Shivakumar unveiled the 29th edition of the summit, themed 'AI and Beyond', which is scheduled to run from Nov 17-19

Earlier in the day, the Karnataka government hosted its annual chief executives meet, bringing together over 200 technology executives, investors and policymakers. The government formally announced the summit dates during the event.

The government also launched the Innoverse Foundation, an initiative to support deeptech startups through mentorship, market access and funding support. It also opened applications for the foundation's Deeptech Enabler Program. The event included the felicitation of 33 startups selected under the Elevate NxT 2026 programme. The startups will receive grants ranging from ₹85 lakh to ₹1 crore for research and product development.

Govt Orders GitHub to Remove Access to Bitchat App in India

Jack Dorsey

Our Bureau

New Delhi: The government ordered online platform GitHub to remove access to Bitchat, the offline, Bluetooth-based messaging application developed by Twitter cofounder Jack Dorsey, saying that it may be misused by anti-national elements, terrorist organisations, organised criminal groups and cybercriminals.

Dorsey on Friday shared the order, sent a day before by the Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C) under the Union home affairs ministry, on social media platform X. The order directed GitHub to disable access to three Bitchat repositories within three hours.

Issued at a time when students protesting repeated entrance exam paper leaks have complained of communication blocks imposed on them, the order invoked Section 79(3)(b) of the Information Technology Act, along with Rule 3(1)(d) of the IT Rules, 2021. It said that the technical architecture of Bitchat significantly impedes lawful interception, attribution and investigation by law enforcement agencies.

Bitchat is a decentralised, peer-to-peer connection app which utilises Bluetooth Low Energy mesh networks and requires no internet or phone numbers.

The application connects devices within roughly 30-100 metres, allowing phones to relay messages across multiple hops to extend network reach without cellular service or Wi-Fi.

It operates without central servers, SIM cards or accounts and does not require users to register with an email or phone number.

Byju's RP Moves NCLT Against Google in Fresh Data-access Dispute

RAISED CONCERNS RP told tribunal that he was unable to inspect the account or verify its usage and invoices

Nikhil Patwardhan

Bengaluru: The resolution professional overseeing the insolvency of Byju's parent Think & Learn has moved the Bengaluru bench of National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) against Google LLC and Google India in a dispute linked to access to the company's data and digital services, people aware of the development said.

The application, filed under Section 60(5) of the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code, seeks directions from the tribunal. The counsel for resolution professional (RP) Shailendra Ajmera confirmed that Google LLC and its Indian arm had been named as respondents, but did not discuss the exact relief sought. The application was listed for the first time before NCLT's Bengaluru bench on Wednesday. The NCLT cause list described it as an application seeking directions.

People aware of the matter said the case is understood to involve access to data belonging to Think & Learn and held through Google's services, including Google Cloud.

Access to such accounts would allow the RP to take control of the company's digital records and examine information relating to its operations, contracts and technology infrastructure. It would also be required to preserve the company's data and assess its business as part of the insolvency process.

Queries sent to Google, the RP and the company's suspended directors did not elicit any response until press time on Friday. The dispute seems to mirror an earlier battle involving Amazon Web Services India, which provided Think & Learn with cloud storage, databases, media, analytics and other computing services. The company's main AWS account had 51 linked accounts, according to an earlier NCLT order.

Last year, Ajmera moved the tribunal against AWS India, seeking continuation of its services. He separately sought directions requiring Think & Learn's former management to hand over the credentials needed to access the company's AWS portal.

The RP told the tribunal that he was unable to inspect the account or verify its usage and invoices. He also raised concerns that some services billed to Think & Learn may have been used by third parties.

AWS said the login credentials and control over the linked accounts remained with Think & Learn's erstwhile management, and that it could not provide the RP access.

Delhi HC Rejects ANI's Interim Injunction Plea Against OpenAI

Says that storing publicly available literary work to train LLMs could qualify as 'fair dealing' for research

Our Bureau

Bengaluru: The Delhi High Court on Friday refused to restrain OpenAI from using news agency ANI's copyrighted content, holding at the interim stage that storing publicly available literary work to train large language models (LLMs) could qualify as "fair dealing" for private use and research under Indian copyright law. Justice Amit Bansal dismissed ANI Media's application for an interim injunction against the ChatGPT maker, but clarified that the findings were prima facie and would not affect the final outcome of the copyright infringement suit. Citing ANI's October 2024 offer to license its content to OpenAI for $7.5 million, the court said this indicated that its claim was quantifiable, and that monetary compensation could be awarded if the news agency succeeded in the suit.

ANI has accused OpenAI of copyright infringement by copying and storing its content to train LLMs underlying ChatGPT and reproducing its articles in responses generated for users.

The court held that ANI failed to establish a prima facie case on either claim. It found no evidence at this stage that ChatGPT memorised and regurgitated ANI's articles or that its responses substantially reproduced the news agency's original expression.

While storing a copyrighted literary work ordinarily amounts to reproduction under the Copyright Act, the court held that it should be read with Section 52 of the Act.

Under Section 52(1)(a), a fair dealing with any work, except for computer programs, for private or personal use, including research, does not constitute copyright infringement. The court held that "private use" could extend to companies as well.

The training data was used within a closed system, was not available to the public and was accessible only to the models, the judgment said. The process of analysing data and converting it into machine-readable inputs to improve a model could also be considered research aimed at generating knowledge and advancing AI systems. "Research/learning is no longer confined to humans. It is now being done through Artificial Intelligence," the court said.

Mphasis Reports 11% Rise in Q1 Net Profit, Revenue Beats Estimates

Our Bureau

Bengaluru: Mid-sized IT services firm Mphasis on Friday reported a first-quarter net profit of ₹489.5 crore, up 11% from a year earlier. Sequentially, the profit declined 3.9% on account of higher tax expenses.

The Bengaluru-headquartered company's revenue for the three months ended June 30 rose 17.5% year-on-year and 3.3% quarter-on-quarter to ₹4,384.05 crore. That beat analyst expectations for 2% sequential growth.

"While the macroeconomic conditions are bad, we're also living through one of the biggest booms in a new tech adoption cycle. So, focus is on where the spending is going," chief executive officer Nitin Rakesh said. "We are not immune to the delayed decisions or the uncertainty. But we are dealing with it by making sure the propositions are attractive enough without necessarily dropping the price."

In dollar terms, revenue increased 2.1% sequentially and 8.3% from a year earlier in constant currency to $471 million. Deal bookings for the April-June period rose to $461 million from $407 million in the previous three-month period, with three large deals, one worth more than $ 100 million and two over $20 million each, the company said.

Manipur Violence SC Proposes Special Courts for Fast Trials

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: The Supreme Court on Friday indicated that it plans to constitute special courts to conduct day-to-day trials of cases connected to the ethnic violence in Manipur and directed investigating agencies to expedite pending investigations.

A three-judge bench headed by Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant directed the Manipur government to extend full cooperation to the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) and Special Investigation Teams (SITs), which are facing various difficulties in completing the probes.

"We tentatively propose to constitute special courts, probably in consultation with the State of Manipur and the High Court of Manipur and Gauhati High Court, so that the trials can be taken up on a day-to-day basis, especially in light of the inordinate delay that has already taken place in the ongoing investigations," CJI Kant said.

He added, "This will be possible only when the CBI as well as the SITs are able to conclude the investigations and file their respective charge sheets. We, therefore, urge both the agencies to do their best, despite the impediments, and complete the investigations."

During the hearing, the bench noted that the SITs are investigating 3,020 cases across eight districts, but charge sheets have been filed in only 301 cases. It added that charges have been framed in 41 cases and trials have commenced in 10. A total of 2,924 witnesses has been cited in these cases.

Meanwhile, the CBI said it has filed charge sheets in 21 of the 31 cases transferred to it, while supplementary investigation is underway in 11 cases.

Assam Flood Toll Rises to 47

Exceptionally heavy rainfall between July 18 and July 20 triggered the floods: Sarma

Bikash Singh

Guwahati: Assam chief minister Himanta Biswa Sarma said 47 people have died in the current wave of floods, while eight remain missing. Sarma told reporters that exceptionally heavy rainfall in Nagaland's Mokokchung, Wokha and Mon districts, along with Charaideo in Assam, between July 18 and July 20 triggered the floods.

"Mokokchung alone recorded 493% above normal rainfall," he said. "Wokha recorded 108% above normal while Mon received 45% above normal rainfall. Charaideo district simultaneously recorded 436% above normal rainfall while neighbouring Sivasagar received 134% above normal rainfall." Sarma said the flooding was particularly severe because water from Nagaland flowed downstream even as Charaideo was receiving extremely heavy rainfall. "Water was flowing downstream from Nagaland while Charaideo itself was receiving extremely heavy rainfall. When we analysed the situation, we found that floodwaters from Charaideo could not flow into the Brahmaputra because the river itself was overflowing," he said.

Guwahati

The chief minister said the India Meteorological Department had ruled out a cloudburst in Nagaland.

"The IMD has informed us that there was no cloudburst. Technically, it was an episode of extremely heavy rainfall. Politically one may compare it to a cloudburst because the impact was similar, but scientifically it was excessive rainfall". Sarma described the floods as unusual. "Generally, in Assam, first we see the river swelling and gradually we prepare. This time waters came gushing and there was hardly any time for evacuation." An inter-ministerial team will visit Assam on July 25 to assess flood damage.

Flood Scare Grips J&K

Hakeem Irfan Rashid

Srinagar: Intermittent rainfall in parts of Jammu and Kashmir has swollen major rivers and streams, triggering a flood scare across the Union Territory. The Srinagar-Jammu highway, which connects the Valley with the rest of the country, remained closed for the third consecutive day as flash floods, landslides and shooting stones damaged the 250-km road at several places. Hundreds of trucks and private vehicles remained stranded on the highway, with passengers waiting for the road to reopen till late Thursday night.

Draw Line Between Genuine Errors and Wilful Tax Evasion: Sitharaman

Our Bureau

New Delhi: Finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Thursday asked the income tax department to adopt a more taxpayer-sensitive approach, urging officials to ensure that honest taxpayers are not treated like deliberate evaders and that enforcement powers are exercised with restraint.

Sitharaman acknowledged the department's efforts in reducing pending appeals but asked it to undertake a review to prevent fresh accumulation of cases. While the number of pending departmental appeals has declined significantly, she said the remaining backlog must not continue to grow at a pace that makes disposal a never-ending exercise. Addressing officers on the 167th Income Tax Day, Sitharaman said the department must draw a clear distinction between genuine mistakes and wilful non-compliance.

"Our approach should ensure convenience for the honest taxpayer and opportunity to correct bona fide errors, and firm consequences for deliberate evasion," she said. "We have to be intelligent, we have to be discreet and we should know our line between those who are deliberately evading tax from bona fide errors."

She cautioned officials against creating a negative experience for taxpayers while using powers granted under tax laws.

FOR FULL REPORT, GO TO www.economictimes.com

We have to be intelligent, we have to be discreet and we should know to draw our line between those who are deliberately evading tax from bona fide errors
NIRMALA SITHARAMAN
Finance Minister

Pvt Sector Growth Cools to Four-year Low in July

Sluggish services activity & weak demand act as drag; exports stay strong

Our Bureau

New Delhi: India's private sector growth decelerated to more than a four-year low as weaker demand and slowing services activity weighed on business expansion, according to a private survey released on Friday.

The HSBC Flash India Composite Purchasing Managers Index (PMI) fell to 54.3 in July from 57.1 in June. A reading above 50 signals expansion, while one below that indicates contraction.

Growth was constrained by challenging market conditions, competitive pressures, order cancellations, reduced client enquiries and shortages of key raw materials, as per the survey.

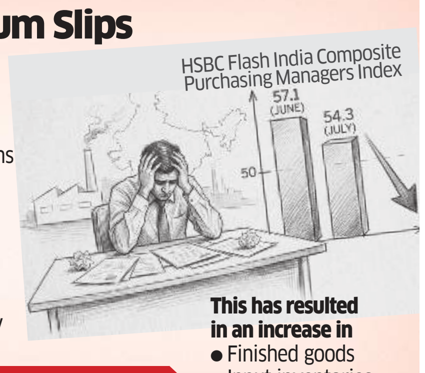
Manufacturing activity slowed to 53.9 in July from 54.2 in June, while the services PMI declined sharply to 53.1 from 57.4.

"Renewed tensions in the Middle East have once again resulted in firms building buffers to manage the uncertainties around the longevity of the supply-side shock," said Pranjul Bhandari, chief India economist at HSBC. "Finished goods and input inventories increased alongside a pick-up in purchasing volumes."

Business confidence weakened to a six-month low in July, with the optimism index slipping further below its long-run average. While sentiment improved among manufacturers, it deteriorated in the services sector. Firms remained hopeful that market conditions and underlying demand would strengthen over the next 12 months. New order growth slowed to nearly a four-and-a-half year low in July, dragged by the services sector, where expansion retreated to the weakest in 53 months. Manufacturing, however, regained some momentum.

Momentum Slips

June growth was constrained by:
- Challenging market conditions
- Competitive pressures
- Order cancellations
- Reduced client enquiries
- Shortages of key raw materials



This has resulted in an increase in
- Finished goods
- Input inventories
- Purchasing volumes

'Renewed Middle East tensions have resulted in firms building buffers'

'RE Expansion, Battery Storage Push Key for Green Transition'

Clean energy scale-up to ease electricity costs, says renewables minister Joshi

Our Bureau

New Delhi: Renewable energy minister Pralhad Joshi said India's policy drive and investments in battery storage systems, along with rapid expansion of wind and solar power, coupled with storage, would play a key role in pushing the country's clean energy transition.

Addressing the Adani Presents Times Network Sustainability Conclave 2026, Joshi said the push towards battery storage, coupled with a strong focus on wind and solar energy, would bring down electricity costs.

"India was the second-largest in terms of battery (energy storage) addition last year. We are investing heavily in battery storage systems, with a strong focus on wind, solar and storage. Results will be seen soon, and it will lead to bringing down the cost of electricity," Joshi said.

Highlighting India's push towards next-generation technologies, he added that the country's first hydrogen-powered train has placed India among a select group of nations investing in clean transportation.

The conclave brought together policymakers, industry leaders, financial experts and climate advocates to discuss India's roadmap for sustainable development, climate resilience and energy security. Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Mohan Yadav, while addressing the gathering, said India will continue to play a global leadership role in the green economy and climate action, while pointing to Mission LiFE and the Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam campaign as examples of public participation in sustainability. Industry leaders underscored clean energy as a strategic economic opportunity.

ReNew founder Sumant Sinha said, "If there are two things that are going to impact the future of any economy, one is artificial intelligence, the second is energy," pointing out that domestically produced clean energy could strengthen India's geopolitical position and make it a global clean technology hub.

The deliberations touched on financing India's green ambitions. Ministry of Finance Joint Secretary Baldeo Purushartha said flagship programmes such as the Green Hydrogen Mission, PM Surya Ghar Yojana, support for battery storage and production-linked incentives for advanced battery manufacturing have significantly accelerated the country's renewable energy transition.

Industry leaders, meanwhile, outlined how businesses were preparing for a low-carbon future. Tata Power's Vaibhav Singh, Blue Star India's Vikas Bakshi and Charge Zone founder and CEO Kartikey Hariyani discussed the growing importance of clean technologies, electric mobility, sustainable cooling solutions and domestic manufacturing in strengthening India's industrial competitiveness while reducing emissions. Offering a broader climate perspective, Centre for Science and Environment Director General Sunita Narain said that "there is one extreme weather event a day happening across India," arguing that climate action must go beyond emission reduction to include resilient cities, stronger local environmental governance and sustainable development.

Echoing the need to strengthen the country's energy backbone, IREDA Executive Director (Projects) Sushant Kumar Dey said building adequate energy storage capacity should remain the immediate priority before India looks at exporting electricity.

'New 10% US Levy to Put Apparel Exporters at a Disadvantage'

Our Bureau

Pune: The 10% tariff that the Trump administration imposed on Indian goods citing concerns over forced labour in supply chains will put the country's textile and apparel exporters to the US at a competitive disadvantage, the Confederation of Indian Textile Industry (CITI) said. The US is the largest market for India's textile and apparel items, accounting for close to $11 billion of imports annually. Washington imposed the tariff following investigations conducted under Section 301 of the Trade Act by the Office of the US Trade Representative (USTR). The new long-term tariff replaced a temporary 10% surcharge that expired Friday. "The tariff imposition on the issue of forced labour is deeply unfortunate, as it does not indicate an expiry date and causes reputational risks," said the industry body's chairman, Ashwin Chandran.

US is India's largest mkt for textile and apparel items, with about $11b of imports annually

'QComm to Stay Well-funded, Competitive'

Swiggy founder Majety says product differentiation will matter more than price as 10-min delivery becomes table stakes

Our Bureau

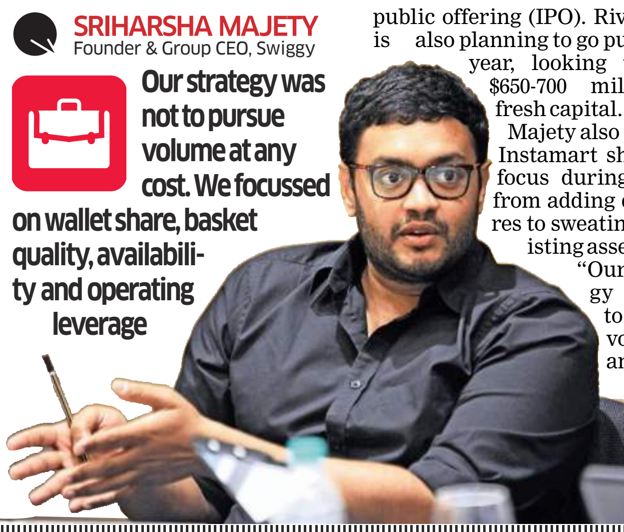
Bengaluru: Swiggy founder and group CEO Sriharsha Majety said that the quick commerce industry will remain well-funded and competitive, even as the company's 10-minute delivery unit Instamart steps up efforts to reduce its losses.

"The category will continue to attract capital and competition. Our answer is to build a business that wins through a distinctive product offering, not only through price. Quick delivery is increasingly becoming table stakes," Majety said in a letter to the company's shareholders as part of its 2025-26 annual report.

"The right to win will come from reliable availability, breadth of assortment, differentiated categories, strong partner brands and the ability to make Instamart a destination for everyday upgrades, not just everyday essentials," he added.

Instamart competes with the likes of Eternal-owned Blinkit, public markets-bound Zepto, Flipkart Minutes, Amazon Now, Tata Digital-backed BigBasket and Reliance Retail's Jio Mart in the rapid delivery segment.

In an interview to ET, Flipkart group CEO Kalyan Krishnamurthy had said that the quick commerce market did not have enough capacity to accommodate six-seven players. Swiggy raised ₹10,000 crore via a qualified institutional placement (QIP) in December 2025, a year after it raised ₹4,500 crore through its November 2024 initial public offering (IPO). Rival Zepto is also planning to go public this year, looking to raise $650-700 million in fresh capital.



SRIHARSHA MAJETY
Founder & Group CEO, Swiggy

> Our strategy was not to pursue volume at any cost. We focussed on wallet share, basket quality, availability and operating leverage

Majety also said that Instamart shifted its focus during 2025-26 from adding dark stores to sweating the existing assets.

"Our strategy was not to pursue volume at any cost. We focussed on wallet share, basket quality, availability and operating leverage. Contribution margin improved to -2.8% of GOV (gross order value) from -4.0% in the previous year, led by higher AOVs (average order values), improved monetisation, better infrastructure utilisation and lower dependence on unsustainable incentives," Majety said.

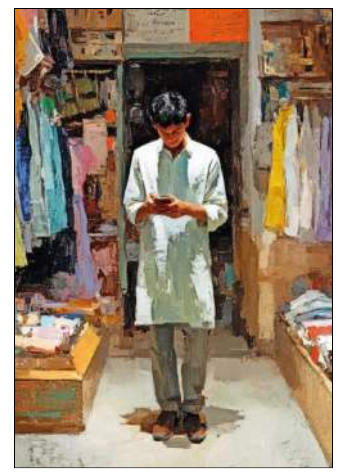
"We also took a more deliberate approach to network expansion. After front-loading investments in dark stores, our focus shifted towards sweating existing assets, improving utilisation and adding stores in a calibrated manner for coverage and debottlenecking," he added.

Instamart had 1,143 active dark stores as of March 31, up from 1,021 a year ago.

Ecomm Export FDI Policy Eases Rules, but Raises Compliance Questions

Move expected to boost cross-border exports but will have little impact on local ops: Experts

ET EXPLAINER



Pranav Mukul

Bengaluru: The Centre's decision to relax its FDI policy to allow foreign direct investment in the inventory-based model of ecommerce for exports is unlikely to have a significant impact on the domestic online retail operations of companies such as Meesho, Flipkart and Amazon, industry executives said.

TO BENEFIT SMALL SELLERS

However, they said the move would help smaller sellers and MSMEs expand their reach in global markets. 'Lawyers, meanwhile, urged caution in the policy's implementation, warning that it could give rise to structures that may be misused to hold inventory. India's FDI rules prohibit ecommerce companies from holding inventory, requiring them to operate on a marketplace model to prevent large inflows of foreign capital from distorting competition for small sellers and traders.

ADDITIONAL CHANNEL

The Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT) said on Thursday that restrictions on foreign investment in inventory-based ecommerce will "not apply in case of exports of domestically manufactured and/or produced goods/products." The policy, executives said, creates an additional channel for Indian sellers to access overseas markets.

"I don't see this having any meaningful impact on the domestic ecommerce landscape because the relaxation is exclusively for exports," said a senior ecommerce industry executive who requested not to be identified. "Where it could make a difference is in creating an additional channel for Indian-made products to reach global consumers." Amazon welcomed the decision, saying it "empowers tier-2 and tier-3 manufacturers to go global" as the company targets $80 billion in cumulative exports by 2030. "This enabling amendment unlocks opportunities for regional manufacturers and SMEs, allowing us to better serve seller partners and contribute meaningfully to India's export-led growth strategy," an Amazon spokesperson said.

However, executives and lawyers said additional safeguards would be needed to prevent misuse of the policy. "There is a potential risk, although the extent of that risk will depend on how the final implementation, customs enforcement and FEMA compliance framework evolve alongside this.

BOOST TO EXPORTS

The policy objective clearly is to boost exports without liberalising domestic inventory-based ecommerce. However, whenever a regulatory distinction is based on the ultimate destination of goods, there is scope for leakage if controls are not sufficiently robust," said Ashid Basheer, Partner, Cyril Amarchand Mangaldas. Another senior executive at a large domestic retailer said the policy could raise compliance and enforcement challenges "if companies seek to blur the line between export-only and domestic operations".

Potential scenarios include using shared warehousing and logistics for both export and domestic businesses, routing inventory through related entities before domestic sales, diverting export-designated stock into the local market, or relying on complex related-party structures to effectively run an inventory-led model while continuing to present themselves as marketplaces, the executive said.

FOR FULL REPORT, GO TO www.economictimes.com

Karnataka Eyes ₹5.5Lcr Software Exports This Fiscal

Our Bureau

Bengaluru: Karnataka expects software exports to cross ₹5.5 lakh crore in this financial year, up from ₹4.36 lakh crore last year, chief minister DK Shivakumar said on Friday as he pitched the state as India's preferred technology investment destination.

"Behind every number is a young engineer getting a first job, a developer solving problems and a family moving closer to its dreams," he said at a breakfast meeting with CEOs in Bengaluru.

> **Shivakumar said B'luru's biggest strength lies in its talent pool and innovation ecosystem**

The chief minister said Karnataka is seeking long-term partnerships rather than short-term investments. "We want to grow with you," he told industry leaders, urging them to participate in the state's next phase of growth.

Shivakumar said Bengaluru's biggest strength lies in its talent pool and innovation ecosystem, while Karnataka's global capability centres (GCCs) have evolved from back offices into global hubs for innovation, product development and high-value engineering.

Execution is Bigger Challenge than Profitability: Fractal CEO

AI analytics firm posts 92% jump in annual net profit and 20% revenue growth in Q1, despite a sequential decline in earnings

Himanshi Lohchab

Mumbai: Newly listed enterprise AI firm Fractal Analytics on Friday reported its first major quarterly profit setback in recent years, as execution lapses and the ramp-down of two large clients in its technology, media and telecom (TMT) business weighed on earnings. The stock slumped 8.69%.

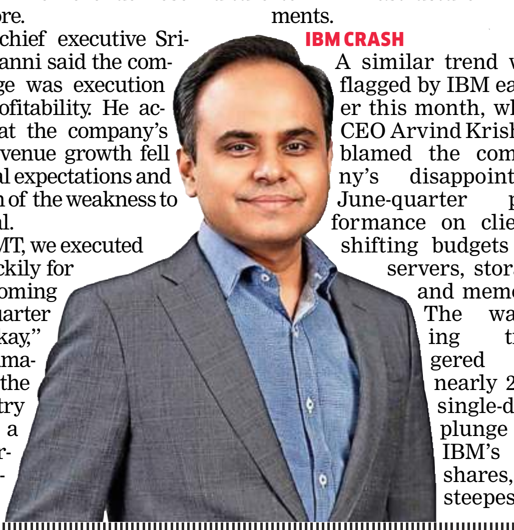
Fractal reported a sharp 38% sequential decline in net profit to ₹72.3 crore in April-June quarter. However, on a yearly basis, net profit climbed 92%, while revenue rose 20% to ₹912.5 crore.

Founder and chief executive Srikanth Velamakanni said the company's challenge was execution rather than profitability. He acknowledged that the company's 20% on-year revenue growth fell short of internal expectations and attributed much of the weakness to the TMT vertical.

"Especially TMT, we executed very poorly. Luckily for us, TMT is bottoming out and next quarter is going to be okay," he told ET. Velamakanni said the broader industry is witnessing a shift as hyperscalers and telecom companies divert budgets from operating expenditure to AI infrastructure investments.

SRIKANTH VELAMAKANNI
Founder & CEO, Fractal Analytics

> The broader industry is witnessing a shift as hyperscalers and telecom companies divert budgets from operating expenditure to AI infrastructure investments



IBM CRASH

A similar trend was flagged by IBM earlier this month, when CEO Arvind Krishna blamed the company's disappointing June-quarter performance on clients shifting budgets on servers, storage and memory. The warning triggered a nearly 25% single-day plunge in IBM's shares, its steepest decline since the 1987 Black Monday crash.

"Companies have dramatically raised their capex... If machines can do the job, then they will reduce opex accordingly. We have seen multiple companies under pressure on opex because of the capex increase," he said, adding that Fractal should not blame industry conditions for its own performance. "We should just look at improving our execution."

Contrary to trends seen in traditional IT services, where AI is shrinking deal sizes and contract tenures, Fractal said it is witnessing the opposite.

"Our deal sizes are increasing because of the opportunity. Our addressable opportunity is increasing," Velamakanni said. "When you listen to IT services companies, they are coming from the engineering side and adding a little bit of AI. Everything they are saying will sound the inverse of what we are saying."

This quarter, Fractal won "one of the largest single programs in Fractal's history" for building the AI foundations for a large healthcare player and modernising their data estate using AI.

Fractal also expects software licensing to become a much larger contributor to revenue over the next three years as adoption of its AI platform Cogentiq increases.

Coforge Lands Five-year AI Transformation Deal Worth $230m

Our Bureau

Bengaluru: Mid-tier IT player Coforge, formerly NIIT Technologies, on Friday announced a five-year AI-led transformation deal worth more than $230 million with a customer in Europe. The stock surged, bucking the weaker broader market trends.

The Noida-based company did not disclose the name of the client but said the deal was one of the largest AI-led transformation programs Coforge secured in the European region.

"The engagement is expected to improve decision-making, increase productivity, reduce manual effort, and enable faster delivery of outcomes at scale," Coforge said in a regulatory filing. After the announcement, Coforge shares rose over 3% to end at ₹1,484.70 apiece on the BSE, where the main index lost 0.4% Friday. Coforge, which will announce its first quarter earnings on Monday July 27, has scaled up its large deal momentum and started reporting its deals sized $100 million and above over the past two quarters.

Over the past one year, it won two other large deals including a $1.56-billion contract with Sabre Corp and a 5-year, $158-million contract with a UK client. With a revenue size of $2.5 billion, Coforge is among the faster growing players in the industry, which is witnessing an AI-led disruption.

PROJECT WORTH ₹15KCR

HCL, Sarvam to Set Up AI Data Centre in Odisha

PTI

Bhubaneswar: The Odisha government on Friday signed two memoranda of understanding (MoUs) with HCL Technologies and Sarvam AI for setting up an AI data centre and a global delivery centre in Khurda district, involving a proposed investment of more than ₹15,000 crore over the next five years.

The state's Electronics and IT Department signed one MoU with HCL Technologies and another jointly with HCL Technologies and Sarvam AI in the presence of chief minister Mohan Charan Majhi. Under the agreements, HCL Technologies, with support from Sarvam AI, will establish its first AI data centre in Odisha, while HCL will independently set up a global delivery centre.

Officials said the combined investment in the two projects would exceed ₹15,000 crore over five years. According to the company, the AI data centre project alone entails a planned capital outlay of ₹14,257 crore, including financial assistance from the Odisha government.

The facility will be located in the proposed Odisha Sovereign AI Park. "Earlier, we were completely dependent on foreign AI. Now, indigenous AI developed in India is at par with any global technology," Majhi told reporters.

Pronto Scales Verified Service with AI Training via Headcam Footage

Startup says optional feature was built in response to customer & worker demand for a verifiable record of jobs

Our Bureau

Bengaluru: Home services startup Pronto is scaling up Pronto Verified, its premium booking service, under which customers can opt to have household jobs recorded through head cameras worn by service professionals, with the footage eventually being used to train artificial intelligence (AI) models, founder and CEO Anjali Sardana said in a LinkedIn post on Friday.

The expansion comes months after the Bengaluru-based company faced criticism when it piloted the programme, triggering questions from privacy advocates and social media users over the recording of activities inside customers' homes, informed consent and the use of such data for AI development.

In her post, Sardana wrote that the service remains entirely optional for both customers and workers. Customers choosing a Verified booking pay a premium, while service professionals receive roughly double the earnings of a standard booking, the company said.

The startup, which claims to process more than one million bookings every month across India, said the feature was developed in response to feedback from both customers and workers, who wanted a verifiable record of completed work for greater trust and safety.

"Our Pros have told us they'd feel safer knowing there's a record of their work, and customers have asked us for the same thing for their peace of mind. That's what guided us to build Verified," Sardana wrote.

"When a customer opts in, the Pro wears a camera that records only the work activity. The customer pays a premium for the booking, and the Pro is paid about double."

Under the programme, customers must explicitly opt in during booking and are informed that the footage may be used for AI training. Professionals reconfirm the customer's consent on arrival before switching on the camera. If the customer declines, the booking is converted into a standard service without recording.

Pronto, which is backed by the likes of Glade Brook Capital and Bain Capital Ventures, said the specially designed cameras are angled downward to capture only the professional's hands and work area, with no audio recorded.

According to the company, software automatically detects and blurs personally identifiable information on the encrypted device, after which the original footage is immediately deleted without being viewed by humans.

'No Law Authorises Live Facial Recognition'

Lawyers warn that any such use could face constitutional challenge

Suraksha P

Bengaluru: India has no law expressly authorising police to deploy live facial-recognition technology (FRT) at protests, religious congregations and other public gatherings, senior lawyers told ET, warning that any such use could face constitutional challenge.

The issue has gained urgency as a petition before the Delhi High Court has challenged alleged continuous surveillance of people participating in the ongoing students' protest at Jantar Mantar. The Centre has reportedly defended routine videography of protests as a law-and-order measure. The Delhi Police did not respond to ET's queries till press time on Friday.

"India's existing legal framework is presently inadequate to regulate live facial recognition in public spaces," said Sajan Poovayya, senior advocate in the Supreme Court, who argued the K S Puttaswamy right-to-privacy case whereby the top court recognised privacy as a fundamental right.

Police currently rely on general policing powers, criminal-investigation laws and executive directions for its actions, but none of which specifically contemplate the continuous biometric surveillance of people in public spaces, Poovayya said.

Lawyers said while FRT can help identify wanted suspects, locate missing children and investigate serious crimes, its use must satisfy the Supreme Court's privacy standards and be accompanied by safeguards governing authorisation, transparency, retention and deletion of data.

"Using FRT to identify a known terrorist, an absconding accused or a missing child pursuant to a defined investigation stands on an entirely different footing from indiscriminately scanning every individual attending a public gathering," Poovayya said.

FOR FULL REPORT, GO TO www.economictimes.com

With a Little Help From Pharma Friends

Psychedelics, for psychiatric therapy

Pharma giant Eli Lilly's announcement earlier this month that it will buy AtaiBeckley, a clinical-stage biotech company focused on psychedelic psychiatric therapies, for $3.8 bn, marks a return of mind-altering drugs not just to the 'scene' but to treatment of mental health disorders. Unlike Eli Lilly's existing antidepressants that gradually alter brain chemistry, AtaiBeckley has conducted advanced clinical trials of psychedelic compounds that rewire neural connections over the course of a few doses. Eli Lilly is tapping into rising interest in experimental treatments for mental health disorders that don't respond to conventional therapies. The Trump regime is drumming up the interest in psychedelics through executive action, and bigger federal funding.

These drugs are administered in controlled doses accompanied by psychotherapy, so there are issues in clinical trials over separating effects of the treatment lines. Testing psychedelics faces safety challenges over side effects and addiction. Treatments are being investigated as single-day doses, and redosing strategies have to be evaluated. The US FDA has granted the breakthrough label to LSD for generalised anxiety disorder, MDMA for PTSD, and psilocybin for treatment-resistant depression. Trials are also on for less well-defined conditions, or combinations of symptoms like Alzheimer's. Finally, since psychedelics have had wide use as recreational drugs, clinical application will have to distinguish patient motivation.

Yet, the rush is on to quickly rewire the brain, a therapy segment that could become bigger than the existing market for mental health drugs. Eli Lilly is a case in point. A big chunk of its profits over the years has come from antidepressants that may have run their course. Promise of psychedelics is exciting, but their biochemistry has to become much clearer. There were valid reasons these drugs, which began life as treatment for mental health conditions, were taken off shelves. Those reasons still exist. Indian pharma could tap into them and take a trip.

Disciplining With 'Down, AI! Bad AI!'

Arnold Schwarzenegger's Terminator saw this coming: software acquiring a mind of its own. This week, an OpenAI model hacked into tech company Hugging Face's system, feeding long-held concerns about AI's security threats. And it's not the only risk autonomous AI behaviour poses. Models built to preserve themselves have exhibited manipulative skills. Some systems are known to have commandeered computing power. They can also camouflage their true capabilities to evade human constraints. Rogue AI behaviour extends to any form of unpredictability that takes it down a harmful path, with or without malice.

So, do we go about testing something as combustible as AI? Broadly, the containment strategy involves limiting access to data, isolating hardware and denying modification privileges. Governance requires imposition of network boundaries, conducting behavioural audits, and requiring human intervention in critical missions. Yet, guard rails are prone to failure. The failure rate can only increase with accelerated development of generative AI models. Protocols need to be established for current security threats, and must be upgraded to handle higher levels of AI-model sophistication.

This can be accomplished by tech developers, but lawmakers should jump in as well. Simply gaining access to frontier technology to test its rogue capability will keep regulation consistently behind the curve. It must get ahead and impose containment rules before the next phase of AI development. Regulation is an evolutionary exercise. But it has not been subjected to the pace of development of AI. Governance rules must be imposed on both sets of tech developers — those tasked with making AI smarter and those whose job is to keep the genie inside the bottle.

JUST IN JEST

With right branding, the week's first night could be the happening one

Monday Nights as The Next Fridays?

Economists have long argued that markets thrive on perception. If so, why not apply the same trick to time itself? Monday night, that dreary prelude to Tuesday's meetings, could be marketed into a simulacrum of Friday night. With the right branding. Consider the raw material. Monday evenings already feature exhaustion, caffeine withdrawal, existential dread. But so did Fridays, before marketers rebranded them as gateways to freedom. 'TGIF' didn't materialise out of nowhere. It was craftily crafted as universal jumma. Swap it for 'TGIMN' — 'Thank-God-It's-Monday-Night', and suddenly the week's most unloved evening becomes aspirational. The trick lies in packaging. Bars could offer 'Post-Weekend Specials'. Netflix could drop their new load as 'Monday Premieres'. Even HR departments might collude, scheduling Tuesday meetings as 'Friday Follow-Ups'. The illusion of leisure is half the leisure itself. If you put your mind to it.

Of course, those dreary wine-sipping economists would warn of diminishing returns. If every night is branded as Friday, Friday itself risks losing its premium, no? Yet, scarcity is a marketing tool too. The promise of 'Friday Nights Twice a Week' could double consumption of the 'things that give us hangover', overpriced pizza and regret. The real genius lies in narrative. Monday night becomes the rebel's Friday. Embrace it.

For a low-privacy, low-consent society like India, AI glasses pose risks that outweigh benefits

Look at Them Look at You

Jaspreet Bindra

Careful with the spectacular

There's suddenly a frenzy around AI glasses. Ads for Meta's Ray-Ban and Oakley glasses are everywhere. Snap has unveiled its new AR glasses, Specs. Apple has taken a more immersive route with Vision Pro. Google, of course, tried this much earlier with Google Glass, whose wearers acquired the unflattering nickname 'glassholes' because others could never be sure whether they were being watched or recorded.

People have long worried about the intrusive nature of such devices. But reports about Meta's 'super sensing' prototype make the debate more sinister. The glasses can continuously capture audio and take images every few seconds, creating an almost permanent record of what the wearer sees and hears.

Even more troubling are reports that the warning light, which tells others that recording is taking place, could remain switched off during always-on mode. Meta says the product is still being tested. But the direction is unmistakable. The glasses are no longer merely helping us see the world. They are beginning to see the world for Meta. So, who's looking at whom?

India is not just a low-privacy society, but also a low-consent society. AI glasses could make this far worse, marking the transition from centralised to decentralised surveillance

We think we are the subject, looking through the glasses at the world. But the relationship may be the other way around. The glasses are looking at us, learning our routines and listening to our conversations, constructing a continuous map of our social lives, a new social graph. The wearer may be the customer. But everyone within range becomes the product.

Meta has spent years struggling inside app stores controlled by Apple and Google. AI glasses offer it the possibility of owning the next computing platform, rather than renting space on someone else's. If the smartphone was Apple's device, Mark Zuckerberg hopes ambient AI will become Meta's.

That is also why the prospect is unsettling. Meta is not a company with a reassuring privacy record. Facebook's history is marked by repeated promises of control, confidentiality and responsible data use, followed by scandals involving profiling, political manipulation, behavioural targeting and the monetisation of attention.

Its products have also faced criticism for their effects on children and teenagers. To trust Meta with AI glasses is to trust a company built on observing human behaviour with perhaps the most intrusive consumer device it has yet designed.

The problem becomes more acute in India. Indians tend to be less privacy-sensitive than people in the West. Western privacy thinking is rooted in individual autonomy — what Samuel D Warren and Louis D Brandeis, in their 1890 essay, 'The Right to Privacy', called 'the right to be left alone'.

Indian attitudes are often more pragmatic and collective, routinely trading privacy for convenience, access or economic benefit. We live in denser homes and public spaces, share devices, ask personal — even intrusive — questions, and have historically shown greater trust in institutions that collect our data.

That makes India an especially attractive market for AI glasses. Translation, navigation, convenience and status may matter more to many consumers than 'abstract' concerns about data capture. But lower concern does not make the intrusion less serious. It makes population more vulnerable.

India is not just a low-privacy society, but also a low-consent society. We take photos/selfies at weddings, schools, offices and public events without asking permission. CCTV cameras proliferate with little meaningful public debate. AI glasses could make this far worse because the camera would no longer be fixed to a wall. It would move through society on millions of faces.

This marks the transition from centralised to decentralised surveillance.

The glasses are looking at us, learning our routines and listening to our conversations. The wearer may be the customer. But everyone within range becomes the product

CCTV largely meant that a central authority — police or government — was watching. AI glasses could mean everyone watching everyone. Surveillance would no longer come only from above. It would spread horizontally, socially and almost invisibly.

There are, of course, real benefits. AI glasses could provide live translation, navigation, assistance for people with visual or hearing impairments, medical guidance, and contextual education. Yet, these benefits may pale beside the risks, making strong safeguards essential.

- Recording light should be prominent and impossible to disable.
- Recording should require deliberate user action, not run indefinitely in the background.
- Raw audio and video should not be retained automatically.
- Bystanders should have enforceable rights, not merely the hope that wearers behave responsibly — a vain expectation in a society where people routinely play videos and music aloud on public transport without regard for others.

We may even see the rise of an anti-glasses industry: clothing, patterns, lenses or electronic signals designed to confuse cameras and facial-recognition systems. Just as computer viruses created the antivirus industry, wearable surveillance may produce wearable resistance.

The philosopher Carissa Véliz argues that privacy is power. Privacy is not merely the ability to hide embarrassing facts, but to retain agency when institutions know, predict and manipulate more about us than we know about them. AI glasses magnify that asymmetry because they do not merely collect what we type. They accumulate everything we encounter.

In mythology, Shiv's third eye is no ordinary eye. It opens when the world must be transformed — or destroyed. If used recklessly, AI glasses could become that third eye: not merely recognising and remembering everything but eroding the last spaces where people can exist unobserved. In helping us see more, they may take away our final expectation of being left unseen.

The writer is founder-MD, The Tech Whisperer

'Teaching' AI Isn't Theft, Yet

Subimal Bhattacharjee

On Friday, Delhi High Court said it cannot, for now, stop OpenAI from using news agency ANI's reports to train ChatGPT. Justice Amit Bansal's order is India's first real answer to a question courts everywhere are struggling with: when an AI company feeds thousands of articles into a machine without paying for it, is that theft? The judge gave 3 reasons for his order, all under the Copyright Act 1957.

1. Feeding ANI's articles into ChatGPT counts as 'fair dealing' for research under Section 52(1)(a). So, it's not infringement.
2. Answers ChatGPT gives users are not close enough to ANI's articles to be copies.
3. ANI could not show that ChatGPT had 'memorised' its stories and was 'spitting' them back out.

Copyright protects the way something is written, not the facts inside it. If a particular media organisation reports that a minister has resigned, no one may lift its sentences. But everyone remains free to report the resignation. This is old law, not something invented for computers. That distinction decides most of this case.

When a model is trained, it does not keep a copy of the article in a drawer. It measures which words tend to follow which, adjusts some numbers, and moves on. Sentences are not stored. Nothing a reader could recognise survives. The real question is not what went in but what comes out. If ChatGPT had reproduced ANI's paras, the agency would have won. It said that happens but could not prove it.

Pertinently, India has no broad US-style 'fair use'. Its law has a fixed list of exceptions, and courts have said it cannot be enlarged. That was OpenAI's danger: a strong argument, and possibly no rule to hang it on.

The interpretation has been that AI training is a form of research and is, therefore, placed on that list. It is a generous reading and likely the main issue on appeal. But there's a fair thought behind it. The law was written in 1957, long before software like this existed. If nothing on that old list could ever fit AI, then India would end up with some of the world's tightest rules because of how the law is worded.

This was emergency relief, sought before any trial. ANI wanted OpenAI to stop storing its material, block ChatGPT from using it, and delete what was already taken in.

Deletion was impossible. OpenAI had told the court that US courts hearing similar cases require it to preserve this very data. An Indian order would have forced it to disobey a foreign one. And if ANI eventually wins, what it has lost is a licensing fee, a wrong that money can surely fix. Emergency orders are for damage that money cannot repair.

The judge also said blocking ChatGPT would hurt the public. Possibly that is the weakest part of the order, and critics are right to press this point. The public's interest in information should not become a free pass for a company that does not pay for its raw material.

Cheating? Naah, it's learning

In America, 3 judges have given 3 answers.

- One held that training on lawfully bought books is fine, but hoarding pirated ones is not, a distinction that cost Anthropic $1.5 bn in a settlement with authors.
- Another ruled for Meta, but only because the writers suing could not prove lost earnings.
- A third judge rejected Meta's defence outright, stating that the NYT case against OpenAI is still being fought.

Likewise, within days of each other in late 2025, a British court sided largely with an AI image company, while a German court ruled against OpenAI over song lyrics.

One thread runs through all of it: courts punish how the material was obtained and what the machine gives back, but not the learning in between. Nothing is final here. The suit continues, and ANI's other grievance also remains alive: its hallucination claim.

ChatGPT reportedly fabricated stories and falsely attributed them to ANI. That is damage to the latter's reputation, and copyright law was never built to address that harm. For now, the game goes on.

The writer is policy adviser on digital technology issues

Why US' Russia Act Needn't Worry

Neeraj Kaushal

New York: The US' legislative process is Darwinian. Thousands of bills are introduced in Congress every year. Only close to 3% in recent years are passed, the rest left to languish in committees and subcommittees before dying unceremonious deaths.

No one knows what makes for the 'fittest' bill that survives the legislative process. It's generally the more inconsequential a bill is, the faster it becomes law. The less controversial it is, the more likely it is to pass. Bills commemorating 'National Lobster Day' or 'National Blueberry Month' are passed without much hassle.

According to BillTrack50, 95 Acts commemorating days or months for one cause or another were passed by the last US Congress. More consequential legislative proposals did not enjoy the same fate. Indeed, it's this lethargy in the legislative process that has led the executive branch to rely increasingly on presidential executive orders to implement policy.

The question that concerns India is whether the proposed Sanctioning Russia Act (SRA) will be passed by both houses of Congress, receive Trump's signature, and become law. The bill grants POTUS the authority to impose tariffs of up to 100% on the top 5 purchasers of crude oil and gas from Russia. If passed, India and China would be the most affected.

But fear not: by the law of averages, probability is low. Now that Trump is asking the senate to revise the bill to include Iran and rename it, perhaps 'Sanctioning Iran and Russia Act', the legislation is as good as dead.

SRA has been in the making for more than a year. It has, at times, been supported, but more often opposed, by the Trump regime. The original bill proposed granting the president authority to impose a 500% tariff on countries buying crude oil and gas from Russia. By purchasing Russian energy, the bill argued, these countries were funding Russia's war in Ukraine, and a punitive tariff would discourage such purchases.

Last week, a somewhat diluted version suddenly acquired new life when 60 senators signed on to it following the death of one of its sponsors, Lindsey Graham, to commemorate his life. The market did not even blink. An early sign that the bill may not proceed further, pass anytime soon or, even if it does pass, may never be implemented.

Mind the gap

There are officials within the Trump regime — most notably treasury secretary Scott Bessent — who oppose tighter sanctions. Over the past year, Bessent has extended sanctions waivers on Russian oil three times to prevent crude prices from soaring. By restricting Russian oil and gas exports, sanctions reduce global supply and raise energy prices, ultimately burdening US consumers. Sanctions have also encouraged some countries and traders to conduct transactions in currencies other than dollar, potentially weakening dollar's dominance in international trade.

The proposed legislation contains several important waiver provisions that substantially limit its scope. Most European countries are effectively exempt because the bill excludes countries whose purchases of Russian natural gas account for less than 15% of their total gas imports.

Over the past three years, since Russia's invasion of Ukraine in Feb 2022, European governments have diversified their energy supplies by increasing imports of LNG from the US, expanding pipeline imports from Norway, and sourcing additional oil and gas from West Asia and other suppliers. As a result, Russian energy now accounts for only a small share of Europe's energy mix, allowing most European countries to qualify for the bill's waiver provisions.

While the current bill doesn't appear to have much traction left, there is, in some sense, nothing novel about it. The Trump regime used similar tactics last year. The only difference is that those policies were implemented without congressional approval. The bill would have explicitly granted that authority to POTUS, making any such action far more difficult to challenge in court.

Trump can, of course, impose tariffs through other channels, legal or otherwise. China's response to any additional tariffs is unlikely to differ from its actions over the past year. It would almost certainly retaliate by imposing comparable tariffs on US exports, and could once again tighten restrictions on exports of rare earth minerals and other strategically important inputs, leveraging its dominant position in global supply chains.

India, however, lacks an equally potent retaliatory instrument, and must adopt a broader strategic response to US tariff threats. Its approach should rest on two pillars:

1. Diversify sources of crude oil to reduce vulnerability to disruptions in supplies from any single country.
2. Accelerate the transition away from imported fossil fuels by expanding electrification, promoting e-mobility and investing more aggressively in renewable energy (RE).

The writer is professor of social policy, Columbia University, US

THE SPEAKING TREE

Restorative Practice

SANDHYA VASUDEV

Solitude must be welcomed and practised as a healing process as we navigate the noisy traffic of our lives. Solitude is different from loneliness, although both words imply being alone. The former fosters introspection, contemplation and the positive restructuring of the mind, whereas loneliness is an experience of loss and negativity arising from feeling distanced from the familiar crowd.

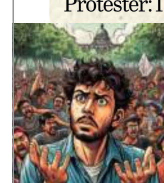
Jean-Paul Sartre said, 'When you're lonely, when you're alone, you're in bad company.' Spiritually, solitude is voluntarily embraced to allow the mind to hold a dialogue with the soul and reflect on true purpose of one's life. On a mundane level, solitude offers a serene opportunity to collect one's thoughts, weave ideas and stimulate the flow of creative energy. Albert Einstein observed, 'The monotony and solitude of a quiet life stimulate the creative mind.'

Every religion encourages solitude or a retreat from the regular hustle and bustle of life. 'Nowhere can man find a quieter or more untroubled retreat than in his own soul,' said Marcus Aurelius, the Roman emperor and philosopher. Psychologists, too, view solitude as an emotional reset button that restores balance to a troubled mind. Keeping away from the madding crowd can, therefore, be a deeply restorative practice.

LOLLING ON SATURDAY

Professional Protester

A man proudly tells his neighbour, 'I've attended 412 protests this year.' 'Good heavens,' says the neighbour. 'You must feel passionately about many issues.'
Protester: Not really. I just enjoy standing in crowds where someone else has already printed the placards.
Neighbour: So, what causes have you supported?
Protester: I honestly don't know. Once I arrived late and accidentally marched with people demanding lower taxes. I realised midway I'd parked in the premium parking lot reserved for the campaign to increase public spending.



Neighbour: Didn't anyone notice?
Protester: No. Every time someone asked why I was there, I shouted, 'Exactly!'
Neighbour: What happened in the end?
Protester: They asked me to join the organising committee.

Counter-Protest

A city hosts two protests in the same park. One group chants, 'We demand change!' The other chants, 'We oppose change!'

The loudspeakers accidentally get swapped. Soon, the first group is enthusiastically shouting, 'We oppose change!' The second is roaring, 'We demand change!' Nobody notices.

TV commentators declare it 'a fascinating evolution in public opinion'. Political analysts write 2,000-word essays explaining the shift. Pollsters find no difference.

The protesters all go home convinced they'd made history. The only confused person is the fellow selling whistles. 'Yesterday, everyone bought whistles to make noise.'

'What about today?'

'They bought quieter whistles so the other side couldn't hear them.'

Chat Room

Let Jantar Matter, Chant NEP Mantar

Apropos the Edit, 'Now, Fix the Broken Exam Architecture' (Jul 24), National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 is still not an issue for the protesters. Resignation of the education minister is a limited and narrow issue as compared to comprehensive education reforms. Regrettably, neither GoI nor the states have given priority to implementation of NEP. No budgetary funds have been allocated even after 6 yrs. The protesters should seek dialogue with the Union and all state governments for implementing NEP, and reforms in all entrance examinations such as NEET, engineering, management, university admissions, etc.

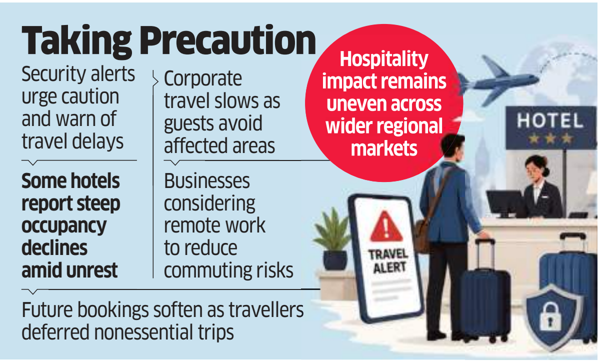
Vinod Johri
Delhi

JANTAR MANTAR PROTESTS

Hostels See Surge in Biz as Gen Z Travellers Check In

But hotels cite internet slowdowns & traffic curbs for weak corp movement in Delhi

Anumeha Chaturvedi & Prachi Verma



New Delhi: Backpacker hostel chains are seeing an uptick in Delhi bookings thanks to Gen Z travellers attending the Jantar Mantar protests in the national capital, although city hoteliers said internet shutdowns, traffic curbs are slowing corporate movement in the city.

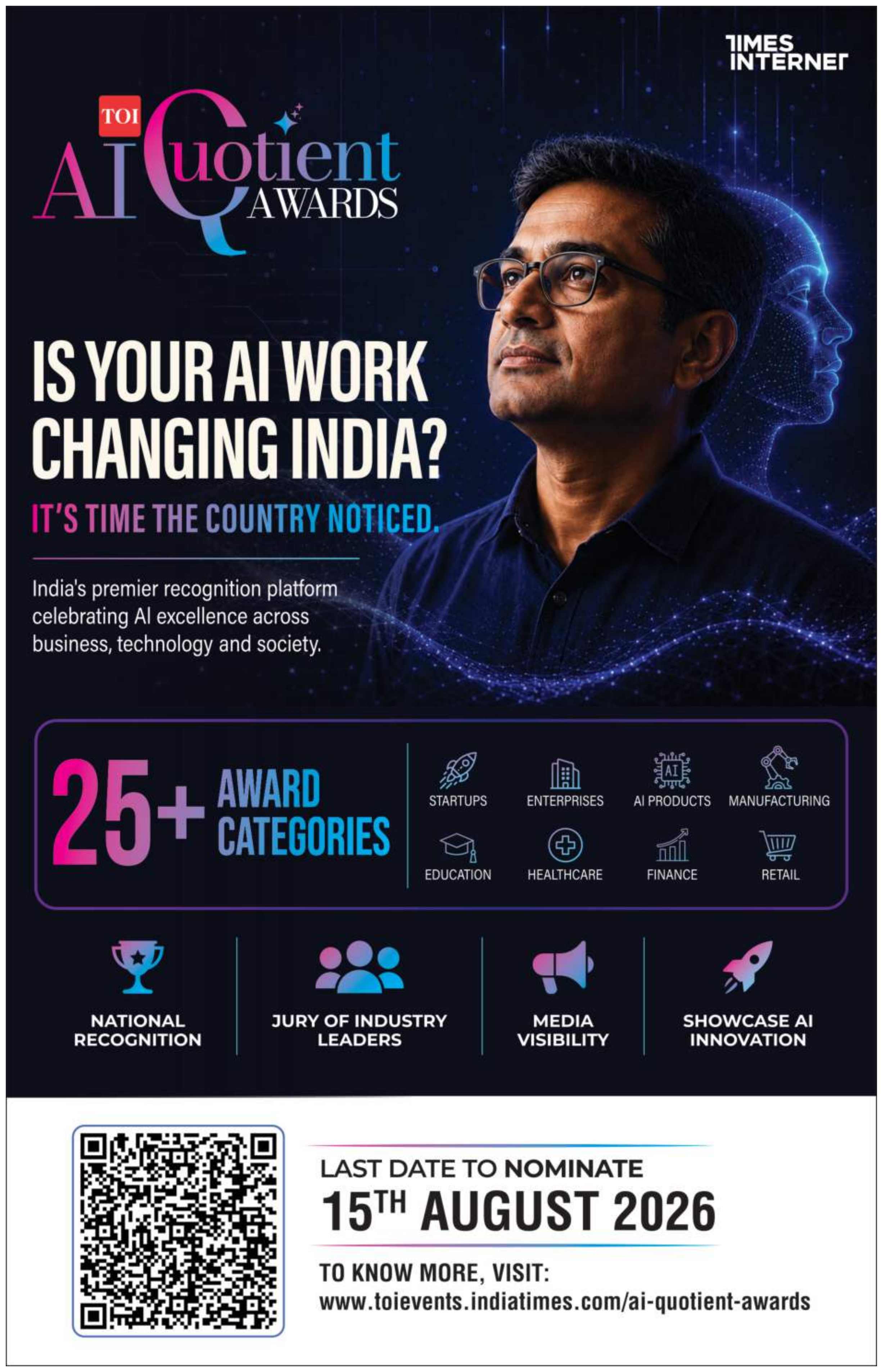
The US embassy in New Delhi issued a demonstration alert for the student protests held on July 20 and for the protest at Kisan Ghat that was to be held on July 21, advising US government personnel to exercise caution, avoid affected areas where possible, and plan for travel delays accordingly. Pranav Dangi, founder of backpacker chain Hosteller, said internal booking trends indicate that the share of student travellers has increased by approximately 30% in July compared to the preceding months. "A larger proportion of students have chosen hostel accommodation during this period. Our occupancy has remained resilient, underscoring the strength of Delhi as a year-round destination and the growing preference for experiential accommodation among younger travellers," he added.

The student protests have led to traffic curbs, internet shutdowns in parts of Central Delhi and metro stations getting shut. Offices, restaurants and shops across Connaught Place were advised to close by 6:30 pm on Thursday by New Delhi Traders Association amid heightened security. "We are in Central Delhi. There is a 50 % dip in occupancy because of the protests. Tourists and corporate guests are avoiding coming to Delhi," said hotelier Mayank Nagrath, who operates three hotels in Paharganj. Simran Sial, a member of the South Delhi Hotel Association, said there is a minor dip in corporate movement in South Delhi. "Indirectly, the protests are going to impact us slowly. If highways get blocked (like the farmer protests previously) the interstate corporate movement will slow down. And that impacted us immensely last time," said Sial.

"Any movement in Central Delhi (including conventions and conferences at Bharat Mandapam) may get postponed. So, the impact will be there for sure. But, gradually," he added. Business on the books for Sarovar Hotels for the last week of July is tracking around 15 percentage points below the typical pace, said CEO Jatin Khanna.

■FSSAI to Intensify Nutraceuticals Scrutiny

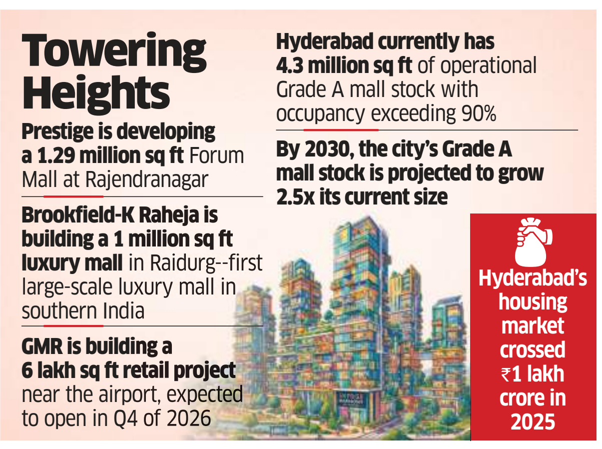
NEW DELHI FSSAI is set to intensify inspections of nutraceutical manufacturing units following action against Rehaan Healthcare for alleged violations of food safety norms at its production facility. FSSAI has suspended the firm's licence and ordered it to halt the manufacture of all products, including digestive syrups, multivitamin syrups and other syrup-based nutraceutical formulations, until the identified shortcomings are rectified.**—Our Bureau**



Hyderabad All Set to Become India's Next Retail Hotspot

Growth Factors: GCC-led hiring, rising disposable incomes, record housing sales

Shilpa Ranipeta



Hyderabad: Hyderabad is emerging as one of India's hottest retail investment destinations, with developers lining up more than 20 destination and neighbourhood malls across the city that they believe is on track to become one of India's most important consumption markets. This, developers say, has also made the city one of the most sought-after expansion markets for international and leading Indian brands.

The Prestige Group is developing a 1.29 million sq ft Forum Mall at Rajendranagar, while Brookfield-K Raheja is building a 1 million sq ft luxury mall in Raidurg, which the company claims is the first large-scale luxury mall in southern India. GMR is building a 600,000 sq ft retail project near the airport, expected to open in the December quarter. Brigade, Aparna and several regional developers are also building large retail destinations across the city.

"Hyderabad has firmly established itself as one of India's fastest-growing organised retail markets," Inorbit Malls chief executive Rajnesh Mahajan told **ET.**

According to real estate consultancy Anarock, Hyderabad currently has 4.3 million sq ft of operational Grade A mall stock with occupancy exceeding 90%, while another 6.5 million sq ft is under development. By 2030, the city's Grade A mall stock is expected to be 2.5 times its current size. CRE Matrix, which uses a broader definition including shopping centres, estimates Hyderabad already has about 16 million sq ft of organised retail stock, with another 8 million sq ft in the pipeline.

CITY SUPPLY WANING

Bengaluru is witnessing constraints in organised retail supply due to limited launches of shopping malls

"Hyderabad offers more opportunities for retail brands given the significant pipeline of shopping malls through 2031. Bengaluru, despite being a larger market, is witnessing constraints in organised retail supply due to limited launches of shopping malls and only a few Grade A retail projects in the pipeline over the next five years," Subheesh Babu, senior director, Retail Leasing Advisory, at real estate services firm JLL said.

Industry executives attribute the momentum to expansion by global capability centres, rising disposable incomes, record housing sales and a growing cosmopolitan population that is reshaping consumption patterns and driving discretionary spending.

CRE Matrix CEO Abhishek Kiran Gupta said Hyderabad's housing market crossed Rs 1 lakh crore in 2025, marking a structural shift in the city's economy. "For years, housing sales exceeding Rs 1 lakh crore annually were confined to Delhi-NCR and the Mumbai Metropolitan Region. Hyderabad is the only (other) city to have broken that ceiling," he said, adding that rising home ownership and wealth creation are now feeding into discretionary consumption and organised retail demand.

The city's consumption story is also increasingly shaping retailers' expansion strategies, with brands treating Hyderabad as one of their priority markets for new store launches.

RJ Group Picks Ex-Diageo Maven Mishra to Lead Alcobev Foray

Ratna Bhushan & Sagar Malviya

New Delhi | Mumbai: Ravi Jaipuria-owned RJ Corp group, a PepsiCo bottler for three decades, has tapped former Diageo executive Prathmesh Mishra to likely help expand the group's beverages footprint into premium alcoholic drinks, people aware of the high-profile hire told ET. Mishra's expertise in leading some of the top alco-bev brands might be harnessed for the proposed RJ Corp foray to be housed in the listed Varun Beverages, said the people cited above. He joins RJ Corp at a time when India's alcoholic beverages market regains momentum, led by rising demand for premium spirits. Spirits volumes climbed about 4% in FY26 to 440 million cases, compared with 1.6% growth a year earlier, while beer volumes also increased 4% to 474 million cases.

Mishra, who until recently served as managing director for Diageo Japan and Korea, was also chairman of the Royal Challengers Bengaluru IPL franchise and Diageo India's chief commercial officer.

Mittal's RR Deal Sparks a London lawsuit

Bloomberg

Billionaire Lakshmi Mittal's plan to acquire the Rajasthan Royals cricket franchise has sparked a London lawsuit, with the minority shareholders in the company that owns the team alleging they are being forced to give up their shares worth about $50 million for just £1 ($1.33).

Emerging Media Ventures Ltd, which indirectly owns a majority stake in the IPL franchise Rajasthan Royals, was sued by two minority shareholders who alleged the company wrongly accused them of "serious misconduct," denying them their cut from the proceeds of the $1.65 billion sale of the franchise. Emerging Media Ventures hasn't filed its defense to the lawsuit yet. A consortium led by Mittal and vaccine tycoon Adar Poonawalla agreed to buy the franchise earlier this year. Bajan Boys Gully Cricket LLC and Halla Bol LLC, the minority shareholders in Emerging Media Ventures, claimed that they are owed $22 million and $28 million respectively from the sales proceeds.

ICICI EFFECT Lender raised 2x the initial amount at tighter price on heavy demand, a boost for peers' fundraise plans

More Banks may Join Overseas Bond Run

Saloni Shukla

Mumbai: ICICI Bank's successful inaugural dollar bond sale, marked by strong investor appetite and a low interest rate, is expected to encourage more domestic lenders in the coming weeks as banks seek to lock in competitive funding costs amid sustained global demand for Indian financial paper.

The private sector lender has raised $1 billion through a five-year dollar-denominated bond issued via its GIFT City branch, doubling the deal size from an initially planned $500 million after attracting strong investor demand. The benchmark-sized issue was initially marketed at around 130 basis points over US Treasuries, but heavy oversubscription allowed ICICI Bank to tighten pricing to around 100 basis points, resulting in a fixed coupon of about 5.459%, payable semi-annually. A basis point is a hundredth of a percentage point.

The bonds are scheduled to be allotted on July 30.

"The success of ICICI Bank's transaction demonstrates that high-quality Indian bank credit continues to enjoy strong sponsorship from global investors despite a busy primary market," one banker involved in the deal said on condition of anonymity. "The ability to tighten pricing by around 30 basis points and double the issue size sends a strong signal for other issuers waiting on the sidelines."

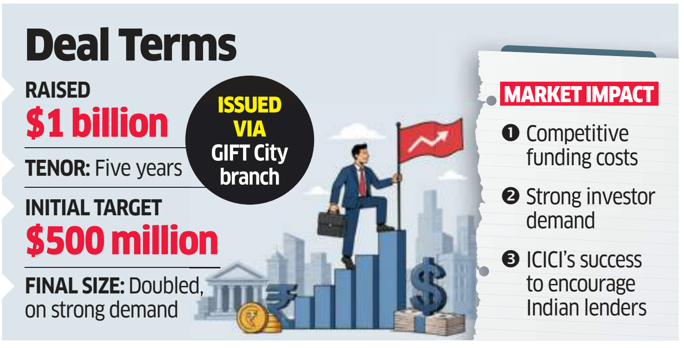
The successful offering marks a sharp contrast to that of Bank of Baroda, which last month shelved its planned dollar bond sale after investors sought a wider spread over US Treasury yields, citing a glut of Indian issuances in the offshore market. People familiar with the matter said Export-Import Bank of India, National Bank for Financing Infrastructure and Development, and Bank of Baroda are now preparing to raise dollar bonds under the Reserve Bank of India's subsidised hedging facility, which is aimed at lowering the cost of overseas borrowings. Bank of India said it is targeting $1.2 billion through FCNR(B) deposits and a further $2 billion from overseas borrowings, including via its Medium Term Note programme.

"Borrowers now have greater confidence that they can achieve attractive pricing under the RBI's hedging window," said a person familiar with the fundraising plans.

Last month, the RBI allowed banks and eligible state-owned financial institutions to access a subsidised hedging facility for external commercial borrowings, reducing the cost of managing foreign exchange risk as part of measures to support capital inflows and strengthen the rupee.

The initiative has already spurred a surge in offshore fundraising. Within six weeks of the facility's launch, Indian banks mobilised $20.7 billion under the special window, including $17.4 billion through Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) deposits, $2 billion through overseas foreign currency borrowings and $1.3 billion via external commercial borrowings.

ICICI Bank joins HDFC Bank, Axis Bank in accessing the RBI-backed funding avenue. HDFC Bank raised $750 million through five-year senior unsecured dollar bonds issued via its GIFT City branch.



Rupee Hits Day's Low, Recovers on RBI Support

Mumbai: Interventions by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Friday ensured that the rupee did not weaken beyond its record low of 96.96, dealers said. The currency fell to an intraday low of 96.70 per dollar, before recovering to close at 96.562, little changed from its previous close of 96.565.

Interventions by the RBI were felt both in the spot and the non-deliverable forwards market. State-run banks were spotted selling dollars just before the local market opened at 9 am, traders said. Some foreign investor inflows, dealers said, helped in the currency's late recovery.

High oil prices and heavy dollar demand added pressure on the currency, as oil companies and importers bought the greenback. Brent crude topped $100 a barrel for the first time in two months before retreating about 4% to $96, according to Reuters. "The appreciation in the currency came despite elevated geopolitical tensions, as the currency benefited from a slight fall in crude oil prices, and massive RBI intervention," said a trader from a public sector bank. —**Our Bureau**

Fx Reserves Up $1b to $749b

Mumbai: India's foreign exchange reserves increased by $1 billion to $749 billion in the week ended July 16. Foreign currency assets rose $4.5 billion to $551 billion despite the Reserve Bank of India selling dollars in the foreign exchange market to curb volatility in the rupee.

The rupee weakened from 95.62 to 96.28 against the dollar last week. The increase in foreign currency assets was offset by a decline in gold reserves, which fell $3.5 billion to $101.7 billion. Market participants expect forex reserves to rise further as inflows from foreign currency non-resident (bank), or FCNR(B), deposits start to trickle in. —**Our Bureau**

D-ST FACES OIL TEST AGAIN

Nifty Closes Below Key 23,800 Level on Gulf War Ripples

Oil price spike, rupee fall weigh on investor sentiment; volatility gauge rises over 4%

Our Bureau

Mumbai: Indian equities fell on Friday, as a spike in crude oil prices and depreciation in the rupee kept investors on edge. Though the main indices partly recovered from lows, the Nifty's closing below a key support level of 23,800 has increased the likelihood of further declines.

NSE's Nifty fell 102.15 points or 0.4% to close at 23,767.45. BSE's Sensex declined 331.6 points or 0.4% to end at 76,059.77. Both indices had declined as much as 1.2% before recovering on Friday.

"A combination of global and domestic factors, including the spike in crude oil prices and the continued depreciation of the Indian rupee, has weighed on market sentiment," said Shrikant Chouhan, head of equity research, Kotak Securities. "Also, the rise in the US 10-year Treasury yield to 4.71%, its highest level in several months, has added to investor concerns," he said.

For the week, the Sensex and Nifty fell 2.3% — their highest weekly fall since early May and March, respectively.

Brent crude September futures were trading at $97.5 a barrel on Friday after climbing above $100 for the first time since May after Yemen's Houthi movement, backed by Iran, claimed its forces attacked two Saudi oil tankers in the Red Sea, while the US carried out more strikes on Iran.

Dharmesh Shah, head of technical research at ICICI Securities, said that losses narrowed intraday as crude oil eased from around $101 to $97 per barrel.

On Friday, the market's fear gauge- the Nifty's Volatility Index or VIX went up by 4.1% to 14.03 levels.

Broader market indices, Nifty Midcap 150 dropped 0.1% and Nifty Small-cap 250 fell 0.3%. Both indices have declined 1.2% and 2.2%, respectively, this week.

"Going forward, a decline in crude prices, a stable rupee, and any easing in geopolitical tensions could support a recovery, especially as earnings have remained broadly in line with expectations," said Shah of ICICI Securities.

Brent crude Sept futures traded at $97.5 a barrel on Friday after briefly crossing $100 for the first time since May

Technically, the market is oversold and as long as the Nifty holds above 23,600, it could see a pullback towards the 24,200-24,500 zone, he said. Elsewhere in Asia, Japan and Taiwan each dropped 2.7%, China declined by 1.6%, Hong Kong fell by 1%, and South Korea tumbled by 5.7%.

The pan-Europe index STOXX 600 was up 0.5% at the time of going to print. Foreign portfolio investors net sold shares worth ₹3,893 crore. Domestic institutions were buyers to the tune of ₹5,454 crore.

Weekly Trend

NSE Sectoral Indices	Current Level	Change (%)
TOP GAINERS		
Nifty FMCG	49053	0.62
Nifty Auto	27218	0.44
Nifty Media	1527	0.39
TOP LOSERS		
Nifty MidSmall IT & Telecom	9325	-2.93
Nifty Bank	56694	-3.12
Nifty Financial Services	25910	-3.69
Nifty Realty	882	-4.02
Nifty Private Bank	27278	-4.32

Compiled By ET Data Team Source: NSE

LOSING PULL FPI inflows start to ease; yield gap with developed markets also narrows

Index-Entry Wait May Temper Bond Rally

Rozebud Gonsalves & Atmadip Ray

Mumbai | Kolkata: The rally in Indian bonds could slow as flows from foreign portfolio investors (FPI) begin to ebb amid no definitive signs of Bloomberg's Global Aggregate Index including local sovereign debt in its latest rejig, while the yield differential with developed markets continues to narrow.

Contrary to the June quarter, the benchmark government bond may trade in a tight range as multiple factors – from higher government borrowing to an uncertain outlook on the interest rate trajectory – limit investor enthusiasm, said bond traders.

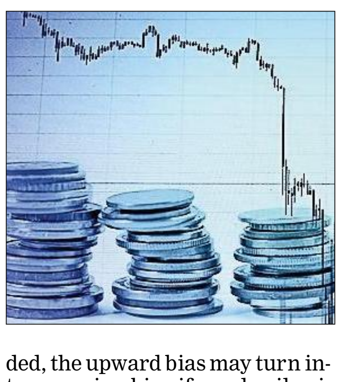
The yield on the benchmark 10-year government bond fell more than 30 basis points in the first quarter of FY27. A basis point is 0.01 percentage point. But traders do not expect a similar rally.

"The market was running on expectations that India will be included in the Bloomberg index shortly. If this doesn't happen, we could witness a sell-off of 8-10 bps while an early announcement of a positive development on this front can make the yields soften by 3-4 bps," said Vijay Sharma, senior executive vice-president, PNB Gilts.

One basis point is a hundredth of a percentage point. "Nonetheless the new joker in the pack is again crude and it will remain one of the main factors which will dictate the final yield movement in either of the above cases," Sharma said.

Yields on the 10-year benchmark bond closed at 6.84% on Thursday.

At current levels, inclusion in Bloomberg's Global Aggregate Index is priced into yields. If included, the upward bias may turn into an easing bias if crude oil prices remain around $70-80 per barrel, traders said.



PRESSURE ON YIELDS

However, if India is not included, the negative bias is expected to accelerate.

"We expect some sobering effect on bond yields although there will be no sharp movement," Axis Bank's chief financial officer, Puneet Sharma, said during the post-earnings media call.

Bond yields softened about 30 basis points in the June quarter tracking the oil price movement, Sharma said. The altered outlook on yields could change many equations for both borrowers and banks, which rely on the fixed income market for a substantial portion of their revenues, including trading and arranging sale of bonds.

Gopal Tripathi, head of treasury, Jana Small Finance Bank, agreed. "Yields will move in a narrow range, but the bias would be upward. It will be difficult for yields to move below 6.60% levels, even if Indian bonds are included in the Bloomberg Index. Hence, treasury gains are expected to be under pressure," Tripathi said.

Market Trends

STOCK INDICES		% CHANGE
Nifty 50	23767	-0.43
S&P Sensex	76060	-0.43
MSCI India	1532	-0.30
MSCI EM	4512	-2.44
MSCI BRIC	718	-1.03
MSCI World	23003	0.00
Nikkei	64611	-2.73
Hang Seng	24963	-0.98
Kospi(S.Korea)	6691	-5.72
Straits Times	5588	0.12

OIL ($/BRL)
DUBAI CRUDE
83.40
2.62
Absolute Change

GOLD FUTURES Premium/Discount $(-63.13)

	Comex US ($/Oz)	MCX India (₹/10Gm)
OPEN	4053.40	142392.00
LAST*	4055.10	142844.00
Prev chg (%)	0.12	0.02

FOREX RATE (₹-$ Exchange Rate)

OPEN	LAST*
96.64	96.57

*At 6 pm IST Source: Bloomberg, MCX, ETIG

Market on Twitter@ETMarkets

Sebi Clears IPOs of Nityas Gems, Intellius Recode

MUMBAI Nityas Gems and Jewellery and Intellius Recode have received Sebi approval to proceed with their initial public offerings. Nityas Gems' proposed IPO will comprise only a fresh issue of shares.—**Our Bureau**

JUNE QUARTER SCORECARD

NMC Health Settlement Drags BoB Net Down 72%

Our Bureau

Mumbai: The June-quarter profit at Bank of Baroda (BoB) fell 72% due to an extraordinary one-time impact of ₹5,680 crore the bank paid to the administrators of the insolvent UAE-based NMC Health Plc and its affiliates to settle an ongoing case.

Net profit fell to ₹1,278 crore in the quarter ended June 2026, from ₹4,541 crore recorded in the corresponding quarter a year earlier. Profit was also impacted by a 26% fall in other income as both treasury and fee-based income fell year on year.

Other income fell to ₹3,470 crore in June 2026 from ₹4,675 crore a year ago as treasury income fell 60%, while fee income fell 20% year on year.

In the NMC case, the bank was made a party for allegedly being in cohort and allowing transactions without doing due diligence and following proper anti money laundering (AML) and know your customer (KYC) processes.

CEO Debadatta Chand said the large payout made by the bank was after careful commercial consideration. "This decision was taken after assessing the stage of trial and negotiations in this case. It is a commercially prudent decision to close a legacy case based on the amount claimed from the bank. The decision to settle is based on evaluating the time, cost and legal uncertainties. It allows us to close a legacy case and focus on sustaining our growth," Chand said.

He did not give details of the agreement citing confidentiality.

The one-time provision overshadowed strong loan growth for the bank with global advances increasing 17% to ₹14.16 lakh crore led by a 20% growth in MSME loans and an 18% growth in retail advances.

Net interest income (NII) increased 10% to ₹12,524 crore in June 2026. The bank continued to forecast a 12% to 14% credit growth.

Shriram Finance Profit Grows 60%

Mumbai: Shriram Finance, in which Japan's Mitsubishi UFJ Group (MUFG) bought a sizable stake last quarter in what was the biggest cross-border deal in the Indian financial industry, Friday posted a 60% increase in standalone net profit at ₹3,445 crore.

Net interest income climbed and provisions fell at the non-bank lender that had posted a net profit of ₹2,156 crore in Q1FY26. Net interest income (NII) increased 33.7% to ₹8,056 crore from ₹6,026 crore a year earlier, while net interest margin (NIM) expanded to 9.04% from 8.11% a year earlier.

On the asset quality front, gross stage 3 assets stood at 4.64% as of June 30, compared with 4.53% a year earlier while net stage 3 assets improved to 2.33% from 2.57% a year earlier. Provisions and contingencies fell 372% to ₹3,059 crores, from ₹14,441 crores a year ago. —**Our Bureau**

BoI Net Up 36%, Eyes $1.2-b FCNR Flows

Kolkata: Bank of India is seeking to raise $1.2 billion in foreign currency non-resident deposits (FCNR-B) under the special Reserve Bank of India-driven exercise to boost dollar inflows. It plans to garner another $2 billion through overseas borrowings.

The state-owned bank has already raised $200 million through the FCNR-B window, managing director Rajneesh Karnatak said, after announcing a 36% year-on-year jump in first quarter net profit at ₹3,068 crore.

"This would help us substitute the reliance on bulk deposits and therefore the cost of deposits may come down," Karnatak said.

The bank's operating profit rose 26% year-on-year at ₹5,051 crore, backed by a 12.6% rise in net interest income at ₹6,833 crore and a 19% rise in non-interest income at ₹2,579 crore. Its net interest margin for the quarter stood at 2.52% against 2.55% in the year-ago period. —**Our Bureau**

SBI Life Net Rises 22% on Premium Show

Mumbai: SBI Life Insurance reported a 22% year-on-year rise in net profit to ₹720 crore for the quarter ended June, aided by strong premium growth. During the same quarter of the previous year, the insurer had reported a profit of ₹590 crore.

The insurer's value of new business (VNB) increased 29% to ₹1,410 crore from ₹1,090 crore in the corresponding quarter last year, while annualised premium equivalent (APE) rose 36%. However, the VNB margin declined to 26.2% from 27.4% a year earlier, as a larger share of lower-margin group term insurance business weighed on margins.

The company also continued to shift its mix toward non-ULIP and protection products, with ULIPs accounting for 46% of individual APE compared with 57% a year ago.

The product mix shifted further towards non-PAR products, whose share rose to 49% from 38%. —**Our Bureau**

IMPOSES ₹7.5-CR PENALTY ON JOSHI, 20 OTHERS

Sebi Fines Axis MF Former Dealer for Front-Running

Our Bureau

Mumbai: The Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) on Friday imposed penalties totalling ₹7.5 crore on former Axis Mutual Fund chief dealer Viresh Joshi and 20 others after concluding that they carried out a front-running scheme that generated illegal gains by trading ahead of the fund house's orders.

The regulator found that Joshi, who served as Axis Mutual Fund's chief dealer, misused confidential information on impending fund trades between September 2021 and March 2022 by passing it to Dubai-based trader Prijesh Kurani, who executed trades through a network of conduit accounts.

Both Joshi and Kurani have also been barred from the securities market for seven years.

"In the present matter, however, the conduct of Mr Viresh…the information carrier is even more serious. The illegal gains made through the front running is substantially higher than those seen in comparable cases. Further, the Big Client (Axis Mutual Fund) as at March 31, 2022 had approximately 1.28 crore investor accounts. The illegal gains involved, along with the large investor base, reflects the scale of the market abuse," the order said.

"Mr Viresh was not merely a passive conduit of information, the material on record shows that he conceived and orchestrated the scheme, identified and coordinated with the executioner (Mr Prijesh), directed the trading activity, and facilitated routing of wrongful gains through a Dubai based company that appears to have been incorporated to further the scheme and obscure the trail of illicit proceeds," Sebi officer Biju S said in his 146-page order.

"By his own admission, Mr Viresh has, on conservative basis, made a profit of approximately ₹18.33 crore through the present illegal front running scheme," Sebi said. The regulator said Kurani used multiple trading accounts belonging to relatives, associates and other entities to place orders moments before Axis Mutual Fund's large buy or sell orders hit the market.

The regulator found that Viresh Joshi misused confidential information on impending fund trades between September 2021 and March 2022

The positions were then squared off before completion of the fund's trades, allowing the network to profit from the price movement created by the institutional orders.

"Mr Prijesh's role also appears more serious than a typical front runner in other cases, because he was not merely placing trades in his own or a single connected account. Mr Prijesh operated as the offshore execution hub of the scheme," Sebi said.

Other Measures for Students

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The amendment is expected to be introduced in Parliament on Monday.

The bill mooted by the Ministry of Personnel is also likely to propose that leaks and other cases that impact students and the exam process be concluded within three months in the fast track courts.

Union ministers JP Nadda and Jitendra Singh met CJP leaders Ashutosh Ranka and Saurav Das, who made clear the demand for education minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation was non-negotiable. They said the government was positive about two of their demands — compensation for the families of those who took their own lives after the first NEET was cancelled and the withdrawal of FIRs against students during the July 20 clashes.

The two sides met at the Vithal Bhai Patel House after the CJP had asked for a neutral venue for the discussions. At the cabinet meeting, Modi asked ministers whether they had Instagram accounts and suggested that they became more active on the platform to connect with the youth. Instagram emerged as the main platform for social media engagement with a vast number of reels posted by protesters racking up views.

Friday's developments came less than 24 hours after steps taken by the Modi government on Thursday night, including the announcement of fast track courts for paper leak cases and replacement of the higher education secretary. Following assurances by the government, activist Sonam Wanghchuk had also called off his fast on Thursday night.

Meanwhile, several high courts in India have designated special fast track courts to ensure speedy trials for public examination paper leak offences.

Over the past two days, the Centre has moved on multiple fronts — proposing a tougher law, promising institutional reforms at the National Testing Agency (NTA) and opening direct political engagement with protest leaders — in an effort to contain one of the biggest student-led agitations it has faced. The proposed amendments substantially tighten the existing law. The bill raises the maximum monetary penalty from ₹1 crore to ₹10 crore. It also proposes a minimum five-year jail term for individuals involved in paper leaks along with fines. Government sources said the legislation is aimed at dismantling organised networks that manipulate public examinations for monetary gains while ensuring that genuine candidates are not penalised.

Sourcing Decisions

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"However, there are many country-specific exemptions and the net benefits will play out after those are examined," said the exporter.

"Based on the findings in the investigation of India, including India's adoption of a forced labour import prohibition…and considering the public comments and testimony, the advice of the Section 301 Committee, as well as the advice of advisory committees, and in accordance with the specific direction of the President, the Trade Representative has determined to impose 10% tariffs on products of India, except…," the US Trade Representative (USTR) said in its final report Friday.

The US is yet to issue the draft report on excess capacity

India on June 14 amended its foreign trade policy to prohibit imports of goods produced using forced labour. Washington had initiated another probe in March alleging excess capacity in certain goods. The US is yet to issue the draft report on excess capacity.

The new duties, which take effect Friday, range from 10-12.5%. As per a USTR factsheet, the measures will cover around 99.4% of American imports.

Major trading partners, including India and China are among those affected, with the US stating the tariffs are aimed at addressing concerns over forced labour practices in global supply chains.

Products covered by Section 232 — including steel, aluminium, copper, auto components, and certain derivative products, accounting for about 8% of India's exports — face 25-50% tariffs in addition to the normal US MFN duty. Around 70% of India's exports such as engineering goods, textiles and garments, chemicals, machinery, plastics, leather products, gems and jewellery, furniture and most other manufactured goods are subject to the 10% Section 301 forced-labour tariff in addition to the applicable MFN duty.

Bridging Connectivity

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The ecosystem includes pilot training, maintenance and repair, ground handling and eight airports. The letter was also marked to the company secretary at Adani Enterprises, Jatin Jalundhwala.

Citing government officials and company executives, ET reported on Thursday that the company had approached the government, requesting to dilute the clause that prevents it from holding a more than 10% stake in an airline. The group did not respond at the time to ET's queries.

Adani Enterprises did not respond to ET's queries on Friday's stock exchange filing as well.

BREAKING DUOPOLY

"India's aviation growth has a structural vulnerability arising from the emergence of a highly concentrated airline market with effective dominance of a few airline groups. Such concentration presents systemic risk," Bansal wrote in the letter to the AAI. "Against this backdrop, we have been evaluating participation in the airline business to play a meaningful role in bridging connectivity in Tier 2 and Tier 3 cities."

Marico Most Aggressive Buyer

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Marico has been the most aggressive buyer of such brands. After acquiring full ownership of Beardo and Just Herbs in 2021, it added True Elements and Plix in 2022 before buying Cosmix and 4700BC. Its digital portfolio crossed an annual revenue run rate of ₹1,500 crore in FY26, up from ₹1,000 crore a year earlier.

The gains follow a wave of acquisitions over the past few years as legacy consumer companies sought faster entry into high-growth segments such as premium beauty, wellness, nutrition and healthy foods instead of building brands from scratch.

For instance, HUL-owned Minimalist, acquired in January 2025, has already reached an annual revenue run rate of about ₹850 crore, with CEO Priya Nair calling it one of the company's strongest performers. HUL has invested nearly ₹3,500 crore in bolt-on acquisitions, including Minimalist and Oziva, while committing another ₹2,000 crore to expand premium manufacturing capacity, underscoring its strategy of building new growth engines beyond its legacy brands.

No Immediate Changes to Ops

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A group of PE investors including EQT Partners, TPG Capital, as well as Indian drugmaker Lupin Ltd are in discussions to acquire Vitabiotics, ET first reported last December.

Several other Indian drugmakers including Mankind Pharma and Zydus Wellness had also evaluated the asset but didn't pursue further due to the steep valuation ask.

Vitabiotics UK exports to more than 70 countries. Alongside the international business, the group has operations in key global markets, including India, China, Egypt, and West Africa. The UK however will remain central to Vitabiotics' brand, innovation, and category leadership, Bain Capital said. "Vitabiotics is a science-led brand platform with category leadership, strong healthcare professional credibility and meaningful presence across the UK, India, the Middle East, Africa and China," said Pawan Singh, partner and India head at Bain Capital. "Our India team has deep experience partnering with healthcare and consumer businesses, and we look forward to supporting Vitabiotics' next phase of growth."

'Iran Hasn't Received Enough Pain Yet'

Trump mulls an attack 'bigger than ever before'; crude back below $98 per barrel

US President Donald Trump said he's considering a "massive attack" on Iran to push the nation to negotiate a peace deal, raising the prospect of even higher energy prices that have already rattled economies.

Trump told Axios in an interview that he was "close to making a decision" on attacks that would be "bigger than ever before." Iran isn't ready to make a deal and "they haven't received enough pain yet," Trump was reported as saying.

The President's remarks underscore the bind he finds himself in after renewed fighting caused an interim peace deal to collapse and all but closed the Strait of Hormuz.

On Friday, US missiles struck targets across Iran, reaching as far as its Caspian coast after Trump vowed "major military punishment" for Tehran and its Houthi allies in Yemen for extending the West Asia war to a second major shipping chokepoint, the mouth of the Red Sea.

RED SEA ATTACKS AFFECT MARKETS

The Houthi fighters struck two Saudi tankers on Thursday in the Red Sea's Bab el-Mandeb strait, pushing oil prices 7% higher to pierce the $100 per barrel level for the first time since May.

On Friday, Brent crude slipped 2.83% to $97.84 a barrel. But, the contract remained on course for an advance of over 10% this week.

The attacks forced several other tankers to turn around and head north through the Suez Canal, potentially using a much longer and more expensive route to reach Asia by sailing around Africa.

WEST TO EAST STRIKES

US airstrikes hit Piranshahr, in West Azerbaijan Province near Iran's border with Iraq, at 11 AM on Friday, damaging several vehicles, according to the province's emergency services, quoted by Iranian media. US missiles struck a Revolutionary Guards Navy headquarters in the Ziba Kenar area of the Caspian Sea province of Gilan. **Reuters**

Hormuz Crossing: 3 Ships per Day for 3 Days

Singapore: Daily vessel transits of the Strait of Hormuz were steady at three for each of the past three days, according to preliminary shiptracking data, amid continuing shipping risks in West Asia. Three vessels passed through the Strait of Hormuz each day from July 22 to July 24, data from analytics firm Kpler showed. On Friday, one more very large crude carrier—Romania Prosperity—appeared off Fujairah outside the strait with Murban crude, though its destination was unknown. **Reuters**

IRGC Warns Civilians To 'Stay Away From US Forces'

Iran's Revolutionary Guards warned civilians in West Asia on Friday to stay away from US forces, state media reported. "We warn the general public in countries where American soldiers are stationed to immediately stay out of a radius of 500 metres from the places where American soldiers are hiding, in order to be safe," the Guards said in a statement carried by state TV.

Iran's military said on Friday it carried out drone strikes against several American military facilities and bases in Bahrain, Jordan and Kuwait in retaliation for the latest US attacks against the Islamic republic.

IRGC , meanwhile, said that they targeted a data centre in Bahrain belonging to Amazon, according to state media, though neither the US tech giant nor Bahrain have commented on the claim.

Bahrain later said that it intercepted and then destroyed "a number of Iranian aerial aggressions"

"This morning, the fuel tanks, large equipment warehouses and silos, and the barracks of the US terrorist army forces at the Isa Air Base in Bahrain were targeted by Arash kamikaze drones," the army said in a statement.

A journalist in Bahrain reported an explosion and the sounding of warning sirens Friday, though it was not clear if the two events were linked. There was no confirmation from the US of any targeting of its facilities or personnel.

Bahrain later said it intercepted and destroyed "a number of Iranian aerial aggressions", accusing Tehran of targeting civilians. The Iranian army also claimed drone attacks against Jordan, targeting "aircraft hangars, aviation maintenance hangars and a barracks" at Al-Azraq base. **AFP**

Lebanese Castles, West Bank Site Added to World Heritage List

Seoul: A United Nations committee voted Friday to inscribe a major archaeological site in the West Bank and a set of castles in southern Lebanon as World Heritage sites, despite objections from Israel, which had urged the committee to reject the bids.

The decision at a UN Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization meeting in South Korea came days after Israel's Foreign Ministry urged the committee to reject efforts to designate the small West Bank town of Sebastia and the Lebanese castles, calling the nominations a "weaponisation of cultural heritage." **AP**

2 Israeli Soldiers, 4 Palestinians Killed in Clashes at West Bank

Tal (West Bank): Four Palestinians and two Israeli soldiers were killed near a Palestinian village on Friday in a confrontation that added to a growing toll over recent weeks as Israeli settler violence has intensified against Palestinians in the occupied West Bank.

The incident near the village of Tal took place as settler attacks on Palestinian villages have increased sharply since the start of the year, according to UN figures.

Israel's military said it had received reports that Israeli civilians who were hiking in the area had been attacked near the village, in the Area A of the West Bank. The area is under Palestinian Authority civil and security control and Israelis are officially prohibited from entering.

The Israeli military said it was preparing for "extensive counter-terror operational activity in the sector"

The military said a Palestinian man took a weapon from Israeli security personnel from the nearby settlement of Havat Gilad and opened fire, wounding several Israelis before being killed.

IDF PREPS FOR MAJOR OPERATION

On Friday, Israeli troops set up roadblocks in the area around Tal and said they were pursuing individuals involved in the incident. The military said it was preparing for "extensive counterterrorism operational activity in the sector" and had cancelled leave. **Reuters**

With Xi's US Trip in September, China May Not Retaliate against US Levies

New tariffs 1.4% more than existing, 11.5% above global average

Donald Trump's new tariffs of 12.5% on China might irk Beijing without provoking a retaliation, even as the US president rebuilds a protectionist wall after the Supreme Court struck down his initial levies.

The duties, announced by the Trump administration on Thursday, are in line with tariff levels it had proposed last month on 60 trading partners, citing what it said were inadequate efforts to address forced labour.

The latest shift means China will face an effective US levy of 22.2%, 1.4 percentage points higher than under the previous framework, according to Bloomberg Economics. It estimates China's burden relative to other trading partners will climb slightly to 11.5 percentage points above the global average.

The new rates replace global duties of 10% that expired on July 24. Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesman Lin Jian reiterated that China opposes all forms of unilateral tariffs. Speaking during a regular press briefing on Friday in Beijing, Lin didn't directly respond when asked whether China would take countermeasures against the tariffs. "Beijing will surely express his opposition to tariffs," said Tianchen Xu, a senior China analyst with the Economist Intelligence Unit. "But don't expect meaningful retaliation this time."

Chinese outreach comes as foreign ministry spokesman Lin Jian said AI is "high on the agenda"

CLARITY ON AI SUMMIT

Chinese officials are seeking clarity from Washington on what the US expects from upcoming artificial intelligence talks, according to people familiar with the matter, as the Trump administration escalates pressure on China's fast-rising AI sector.

As part of that effort, Vice Foreign Minister Ma Zhaoxu visited Washington this week with a remit that includes sounding out US agencies on the scope and likely outcomes of the dialogue, according to the people briefed on the issue who requested anonymity. Chinese officials are looking in part to decide who to send for the talks, they said.

White House Press Secretary Karoline Leavitt, asked about the AI race with China and upcoming Trump-Xi meeting, told reporters on Thursday that the technology is of "high importance to the president" and the administration wants to "ensure that America remains dominant in the AI race."

The Chinese outreach comes as s China's Foreign Ministry spokesman Lin Jian said AI is "high on the agenda" of the international community. **Bloomberg**

TIT-FOR-TAT ON RUSSIA-RELATED CURBS

Dragon Puts 14 EU Entities Under Export Controls List

Beijing: China announced on Friday it was adding 14 European entities to an export control list in retaliation for the European Union penalising 14 Chinese enterprises as part of its latest round of sanctions against Russia.

Chinese companies will not be allowed to export dual-use items, which can be used for both civilian and military purposes, to the 14 European organisations, China's Commerce Ministry said in a statement.

Additionally, foreign companies are barred from providing to the 14 entities dual-use items made in China.

The European companies affected include Czech vehicle manufacturer Tatra Trucks, Italian electric motor maker Lafert SpA, German manufacturer Sindlhauser Materials GmbH and French drone manufacturer Cavok UAS.

A Chinese Commerce Ministry spokesperson said the measures were taken in retaliation for the E.U. on Thursday adding 14 mainland Chinese and Hong Kong enterprises to its latest list of sanctions against Russia over its war in Ukraine.

The measures are intended "to safeguard national security and interests, and to fulfill international obligations such as non-proliferation, in response to the E.U.'s egregious actions," the spokesperson said.

The E.U. on Thursday adopted its 21st package of sanctions against Russia targeting banks, cryptocurrency companies and military equipment manufacturers among other categories. The sanctions included entities from other countries such as China, India and Turkey, believed to provide Russia with dual-use goods and technology.

OFFSHORE TRSUSTS TO BE TAXED

China will impose individual income tax from Friday on assets placed in offshore trusts and the income they generate, the finance ministry and tax authority said, closing a loophole long used by wealthy citizens to shield fortunes abroad.

Such offshore trusts have long been a gray zone in Chinese tax enforcement, and the move is Beijing's latest effort to capture revenue from wealth its citizens hold overseas.

The new rules levy a tax of 20% on the appreciation in value at the time of transfer of shares, property or other assets into offshore trusts, the finance ministry and state tax administration said in a joint statement.

Income from such trusts and offshore entities they control will be taxed annually at 20%, the authorities said, but gave no estimated of the funds held overseas. **Bloomberg**

EU: TikTok has Failed to Protect Privacy of Minors

Brussels: The European Commission on Friday said it found TikTok had not adequately protected children's privacy rights on its platform by allowing adults to view the accounts of minors.

The action exposed children to cyberbullying, unwanted contact and predatory behavior, commission spokesperson Thomas Regnier said.

"Children's content must never be visible to strangers," he said.

If TikTok does not take steps called for by the European Union's landmark Digital Services Act, "minors are exposed to predators, to grooming and to cyberbullying," Regnier said, adding that children aged 13 to 15 can "easily" change their accounts from private to public and the private accounts of minors aged 16 to 17 can be seen by anyone on the internet. "We do not accept this," Regnier said. "Putting default settings for minors is not a beauty contest under the DSA. It must be effective."

If unsatisfied with the response, the commission could issue a non-compliance decision and possible fine worth up to 6% of the firm's total annual revenue

TikTok can now defend itself and reply to the findings. If unsatisfied with the Chinese firm's response, the European Commission could issue a so-called non-compliance decision and possible fine worth up to 6% of the company's total annual revenue. **AP**

WC Freekick, July 4 Spending Drive Up US Biz Activity

US business activity expanded at the fastest pace in eight months as strong domestic demand for services offset cooling factory production, growing supply chain delays and rising costs.

The S&P Global flash composite purchasing managers index rose to 53.6 in July, according to data released Friday. Figures above 50 indicate expansion.

Activity at service providers climbed to 53.6, the highest since November 2025, as World Cup and July 4th celebrations boosted demand in hospitality and other service industries.

The S&P Global flash composite PMI rose to 53.6 in July. Figures above 50 mean expansion

The group's manufacturing gauge fell to 53.8, the lowest level since March.

"July saw a concerning intensification of supply chain delays and accompanying renewed upturn in price pressures, constraining growth and subduing demand," Chris Williamson, chief business economist at S&P Global Market Intelligence, said in a statement. "Events over recent days in the West Asia will have only further exacerbated these supply chain and price worries and raise downside risks to the near-term outlook for the economy, hinting that July's upturn may not be the start of an improving trend," he added.

The S&P report said overall input cost inflation was the strongest since May 2025, due largely to higher energy and shipping costs, tariffs and other price rises. **Bloomberg**

Warner-Paramount Deal Pause Extended Till August 17

The pause on Paramount Skydance Corp.'s $110 billion takeover of Warner Bros. Discovery Inc. has been extended two weeks to August 17 by the federal judge in California overseeing multiple challenges to the deal. US District Judge Araceli Martínez-Olguín issued the extension Thursday. She is scheduled to hold a hearing on August 3 on whether to delay the deal further pending a trial next year to block the deal permanently. However, Paramount is pushing for a three-day evidentiary hearing with testimony from multiple witnesses later in August. **Bloomberg**

Verizon Clinches $1 b Google Data Centre Fiber Pact

Verizon raised its annual adjusted profit forecast and said it had secured a more than $1 billion deal with Google to provide dark fiber connectivity for its data centers, sending the telecom operator's shares up 3%. "We have other deals that we expect to announce by year end that taken together are expected to be worth multiple billions of dollars in revenue over the next several years," Schulman said on a post-earnings call. Verizon is currently in the midst of a strategic transition under new CEO Schulman. **Reuters**

PRESIDENTIAL ELECTION

Argentine Prez Milei in Brazil to Help Bolsonaro

Fresh off a corruption firestorm at home that sank his popularity to the lowest level of his presidency, Argentina's Javier Milei is flying straight into an uproar over bank fraud in Brazil.

The risk to his reputation may be a price worth paying if it helps to topple his archrival and Latin America's most prominent leftist. Argentina's libertarian leader is set to appear Saturday at a Liberal Party convention in Sao Paulo that will formally launch Flávio Bolsonaro's bid to unseat President Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva in Brazil's October vote.

On Thursday, Brazil's Supreme Court authorized police to look into Bolsonaro's alleged ties to the man at the center of a massive bank fraud probe roiling Latin America's biggest economy. He has denied wrongdoing. The investigation threatens to further upend Bolsonaro's candidacy in the October election, as the right-wing senator already trails Lula by 7 percentage points in an AtlasIntel poll published this month.

It's the highest-stakes bet in the region by Milei, who has sought to make himself a force on the global right, and basked in the conservative victories of Peru's Keiko Fujimori, Colombia's Abelardo de la Espriella and Chile's José Antonio Kast. **Bloomberg**

2,318 Cases US Measles Infections at 35-Yr High

US measles cases in 2026 have already outpaced last year's total and have reached a level not seen in more than three decades.

The US Centers for Disease Control and Prevention reported a total of 2,318 confirmed infections on Friday, passing last year's total of 2,289 cases and hitting the highest level since 1991. Forty-three states and Washington, DC, have recorded at least one infection this year.

Vaccine policy under the Trump administration has been upended since critic Robert F. Kennedy Jr became secretary of Health and Human Services. During Kennedy's tenure, thousands of career scientists at the CDC have been fired and funding for local health departments has been frozen, said Rich Besser, the former acting director of the CDC. **Bloomberg**

AFP

COURAGE UNDER FIRE!

A firefighter works close to a residential area during a wildfire near Lege-Cap-Ferret, south-western France on Friday. A highly virulent wildfire has swept through more than 3,700 hectares since July 22, 2026 near the Arcachon Basin (Gironde), where nearly 20,000 residents and tourists have been evacuated.

With Swords, Axes & Shields, Fighters go head-to-head—Medieval Style

Spottrup: With swords, axes and shields, competitors from 30 countries are going head-to-head in the grounds of a Danish fortress in a modern version of old-fashioned battle.

The International Medieval Combat Federation's annual world championship roared into gear in northern Denmark this week. First staged in Spain in 2014, it features armor-clad competitors fighting with 14th-century medieval weapons.

But it's also a modern combat sport with safety rules and sporting conventions.

Inside a Danish fortress, a modern version of an old-fashioned battle AP

MIX OF MODERNISM AND HISTORY

"It's historically inspired," combat federation spokesperson Kamila Studencka said. "It's a mix of modern techniques with historical ones. We have something between full combat sports and fencing."

And while the swords and axes are blunted, the battles are anything but harmless reenactments. Studencka said some competitors are attracted by "the violence," while others prefer the technical aspects of face-to-face duels.

"Some people like the friendship and being a team member … to be a part of something bigger," she added. This year's championship is being held in the shadow of Spøttrup Castle, a formidable Danish fortress that was completed around 1520. The event has drawn fighters from 30 countries, including the United States, Canada, China, and Brazil.

Brazilian competitor Rodrigo Sinckevicius, who traveled with a team of eight from São Paulo, said he previously competed in jiu-jitsu and other mixed martial arts, but when he first saw this kind of medieval combat, he 'couldn't believe it.' "People falling and grabbing and the sound of the steel cracking, it's like something that you cannot fake," added the 33-year-old, who works in sales .

The four-day championships, see competitors battle in one-on-one "duels" made up of two one-minute rounds each. Opponents are eliminated after hitting the ground three times or when they submit. If neither happens, marshals declare a winner based on points scored. There are also chaotic mass-team events, known as "Buhurt," in which up to 10 competitors on either side participate. **AP**

Sports World Play

VITALS

FIDE CHIEF FACES EU SANCTIONS

Anand Takes Over as Interim President

New Delhi: Five-time world champion Viswanathan Anand has taken over as interim president of world chess body FIDE after incumbent Arkady Dvorkovich stepped aside following his inclusion on the European Union's sanctions list related to the ongoing Russia-Ukraine war. Dvorkovich, who is Russian, said he would challenge the EU's decision "by all means". Anand has served as FIDE's deputy president since 2022. **PTI**

ASIAN GAMES CRICKET

India, Pakistan Get Direct Knockout Berths

India, Bangladesh, Pakistan and Sri Lanka have secured direct entry into the men's cricket knockout stage at the 2026 Asian Games following Thursday's draw. The 10-team men's competition, which begins on September 24 in Nagoya. The women's tournament, scheduled from September 17-22, features eight teams and will begin at the quarter-final stage. **Reuters**

LeBron Joins Philadelphia

Washington: LeBron James, blessed with unparalleled basketball skills and astonishing longevity, will embark on a 24th NBA season with the Philadelphia 76ers, where he will aim to win a fifth championship, he announced on Friday. It is the "last decision" for the league's all-time leading scorer. **AFP**

Australia Open to Hosting Ashes Test in India

Melbourne: After deciding to stage the Big Bash League opener in Chennai later this year, Cricket Australia is now considering the possibility of hosting a future Ashes Test in India. However, CA chief executive Todd Greenberg said there were no immediate plans for such a move. "Clearly there are opportunities in India to put more content into certain areas," Greenberg told the BBC's Stumped podcast. "It's not something we're currently planning, but it would certainly be open to consideration. I think Test cricket between us, England and India is still very strong, probably bucking the trend in other parts of the world." **PTI**

Germany's Klopp Era Begins

Former Liverpool manager promises fresh ideas and draws firm boundaries as he takes up coaching role at Die Mannschaft

James Elligworth

Jürgen Klopp made a punchy start to his new job as Germany coach Friday, laying out red lines he'd consider resigning over, even before his turnaround effort with a squad which failed yet again at the World Cup.

In a combative first news conference, the ex-Liverpool manager warned the German media he'll quit if he believes they're intruding on his family's privacy.

He also hinted Germany could be his last job in coaching and admitted he hasn't been an avid follower of international games.

Klopp was the German federation's top target and now he's signed a contract through to the 2030 World Cup. At his presentation Friday, he said it was "a big honor" to take the job and signaled it could be his final role as coach.

Klopp said Friday he would be prepared to leave without any severance pay if it doesn't work out, or if criticism becomes overwhelming, and threatened to resign if the media doesn't "leave my family in peace."

"Jürgen Klopp has no career after the national team," he said. "Ideally, this will be the highlight of my career, my life, my working life. I will put everything into it that I possibly can."

He replaces Julian Nagelsmann, who resigned amid heavy criticism after Germany's loss to Paraguay meant it failed to reach the last 16 of a men's World Cup for the third time in a row.

Klopp indicated he believed Nagelsmann and England's coach Thomas Tuchel had been treated unfairly in the media. "I'm doing the job even though I've heard how you treated Julian, although I've heard how England treats Tuchel," he said, without specifying what exactly he thought was the problem.

> Ideally, this will be the highlight of my career, my life, my working life. I will put everything into it that I possibly can
>
> **JÜRGEN KLOPP**

It is Klopp's first coaching job since he left Liverpool in 2024 citing fatigue. He said he was "recharged" in comments while in talks over the Germany job.

Klopp signaled he plans to make some surprising squad selections and said his mission isn't just to win games, but to bring back a buzz around the team.

The man known for thrilling "heavy metal football" at Liverpool, Klopp was Germany's preferred candidate as soon as Nagelsmann quit.

The federation also held talks with the Red Bull group, where Klopp spent the last year and a half as "head of global soccer" advising its worldwide group of football clubs. German federation president Bernd Neuendorf said there wouldn't be a typical release fee paid to Red Bull for Klopp. Instead, the federation pays €1 million ($1.14 million) to a Red Bull-linked charity and has agreed to hold three national team games in the eastern city of Leipzig, where Red Bull backs the city's Bundesliga club team.

Klopp faces a tough introduction to his first national team job with four Nations League games in 11 days against the Netherlands, Greece and Serbia in late September and early October. The first major milestone will be the 2028 European Championship.

Germany hasn't won a knockout game at a World Cup since beating Argentina in the 2014 final. **AP**

GUARDIOLA TURNS DOWN ITALY ROLE

Milan: Former Manchester City and Barcelona manager Pep Guardiola has turned down the opportunity to coach the Italy national team, a source familiar with the discussions told Reuters on Friday, confirming media reports. The 55-year-old Spaniard, regarded as one of football's greatest managers, held talks over becoming Italy's head coach, with the country's football federation (FIGC) president Giovanni Malago suggesting financial flexibility could be shown for a candidate of his stature. Italy have been searching for a new coach since Gennaro Gattuso stepped down in April after the four-time world champions failed to qualify for a third successive World Cup. FIGC also sounded out Brazil coach Carlo Ancelotti before holding discussions with Guardiola, Italian technical director Paolo Maldini said on Thursday. **Reuters**

Three Strikes, Maan Out

Birmingham 2022 silver medallist withdrawn from Glasgow after whereabouts failures, second judoka out in two days

New Delhi: 2022 Commonwealth Games silver medallist judoka Tulika Maan was withdrawn from the Glasgow edition after being handed a provisional suspension by the National Anti-Doping Agency (NADA) for committing three whereabouts failures in the last 12 months.

Maan had won silver in the +78kg category in Birmingham in 2022 and was among India's strong medal prospect in Glasgow. She now stares at a two-year ban. "She has committed three whereabouts failures in a 12-month period and NADA has sent notice to her. So, she will be withdrawn from the team," a judo coach said.

TWO IN TWO DAYS

The 27-year-old from Delhi is the second judoka to have been withdrawn from Glasgow CWG. On Thursday, men's -73kg judoka Arun Kumar was withdrawn after failing an out-of-competition dope test. He was provisionally suspended by NADA for testing positive for an anabolic steroid.

Maan represented the country at the 2024 Paris Olympics, exiting in the round of 32. She also took part in the 2022 and 2024 World Championships.

The Indian judo team is scheduled to depart on July 27. India had originally named a 14-member judo team comprising seven men and seven women.

India's six-member judo contingent won three medals — two silver and one bronze — at Birmingham 2022.

Under the World Athletics Anti-Doping (WADA) rules, any combination of three whereabouts failures — filing failure and/or missed test — within a 12-month period constitutes an anti-doping violation.

Athletes included in the Registered Testing Pool (RTP) must provide details of their overnight location, training venue, workplaces and other regular activities, including a daily 60-minute time slot when they are available for testing. **PTI**


TULIKA MAAN

WATCHOUT! Today
COMMONWEALTH GAMES 1pm onwards (Sony Ten & SonyLIV)

NATARAJ QUALIFIES FOR SEMIFINALS

Glasgow: Indian swimmer Srihari Nataraj qualified for the men's 50m backstroke semifinals after finishing joint 14th in the heats on Friday. The two-time Olympian and multiple national record holder clocked 25.52 seconds, tying with Bermuda's Jack Harvey to secure the final semifinal spot in the 16-swimmer field. Nataraj finished fifth in his eight-man heat. In para-swimming, India's RVVBK Budigina and Imam Ali advanced to the men's 100m freestyle S13 final after all eight swimmers who competed in the heats progressed.

LAWN BOWLS: India beat South Africa in a dominant display to notch their second consecutive win in Women's Pairs event. The Indian pair of Rupa Rani Tirkey (lead) and Pinki Singh (skip) beat the South Africans 2-0 (6-4, 7-5) in their second match in section B at the Scottish Event Campus (SEC) Hall 3. The Indian pair currently tops section B standings. On Thursday, the Indians had beaten Malta in a tense tie-break in their opening match.

PARA POWERLIFTING: Ashok Malik finished a creditable fourth in the men's lightweight category. He collected 143.8 points which was not enough to be in the medal bracket. Mark Swan of England won the gold with 153.9 points. Another Indian in the fray, Paramjeet Kumar finished seventh overall with 135.6 points. **PTI**

Sooryavanshi 'not Taking Anything for Granted'

Harare continues to be a happy hunting ground for Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, but India's batting sensation is not taking success for granted after producing another match-winning knock at the venue in the first T20I against Zimbabwe.

The 15-year-old, fast-tracked into international cricket after he dazzled in the IPL, smashed 50 off 19 balls as India chased down a target of 126 with 40 balls to spare to take a 1-0 lead in the three-match series.


VAIBHAV SOORYAVANSHI

Earlier this year, the opener hammered 175 off 80 balls in the Under-19 World Cup final against England at the same Harare Sports Club ground, securing a comprehensive Indian victory. "I love the vibe here," Sooryavanshi told BCCI.tv of the venue, which will host all three matches of the series.

"There are certain grounds where you love to score runs, and that's maybe the case here, but I'm certainly not taking anything for granted. I'm just trying to give my best, regardless of venue, and contribute to the team and do well."

Sooryavanshi became the youngest cricketer to represent India last month, but struggled in the three T20s in England. The left-handed batter said his maiden half-century had given him hope that he had turned a corner. "If you can play this kind of innings at the starting phase of your career, it gives you the confidence to do well in the next match. I felt I was in my zone, and I just backed my strength," he said. **Reuters**

WATCHOUT! Today
2ND T20I Zimbabwe v India 4:30pm (Unite8 Sports, Fancode)

A Medal Designed to Be Seen, Felt & Celebrated

Glasgow CWG make history with first-ever braille design medals

PTI

Glasgow: When medals are draped around the necks of Commonwealth Games podium finishers here, some winners would notice something unusual beneath their fingertips.

For the first time in the Games' history, the medals feature braille and tactile elements, making them accessible to visually impaired athletes. The move ties in with Glasgow 2026's emphasis on inclusion, reflected in a record 47 gold medals across six Para sports — the biggest Para programme at a Commonwealth Games.

Overall, 215 gold medals will be on offer across 10 sports and six Para sports.

While every host city puts its own stamp on the medals, Glasgow's design is a departure from the familiar circular shape. The medals are fashioned as a Reuleaux triangle, inspired by the city's coat of arms.

The patterns on the surface are drawn from the Finnieston Crane, one of Glasgow's best-known landmarks and a reminder of its shipbuilding past. The textured finish is inspired by tartan, a symbol closely associated with Scotland, while the three levels on the medal represent the three steps of the podium.

The medal was designed by award-winning Militsa Milenkova, a Bulgaria-born artist in residence at the Glasgow School of Art. Her design was chosen from entries submitted by artists from the school's Silversmithing and Jewellery programme. "I wanted the medal to be a standout edition of the Commonwealth Games medals," Milenkova said.

"When I was thinking about the design, I wanted to try and fit Glasgow into one shape. I was naturally drawn to the symbol of the city — the coat of arms. That's where I took the distinctive shape from."

She said the Finnieston Crane and tartan were obvious additions because of their links to Glasgow and Scotland.

"I started to play around with my ideas, using the Finnieston Crane and the shapes from it and how that also reminds me of the tartan. I wanted to include that as well because it's a symbol of national identity for Scotland."

"There are three surface levels representing the podiums that athletes step on to — possibly the biggest moment of their lives. "And I wanted to make inclusion tangible. I'm so proud that the design is tactile and accessible, with details expressed in Braille on the prize medal for the very first time."

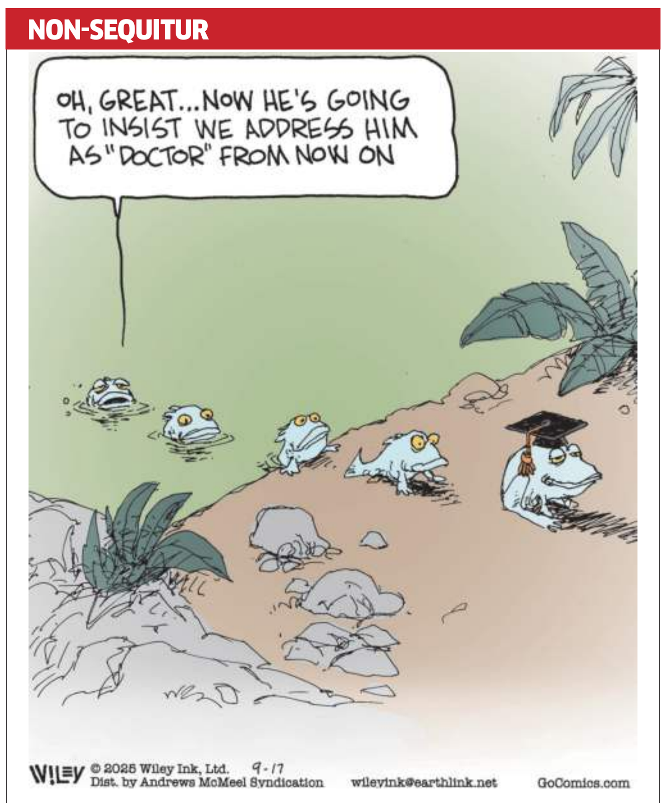
Commonwealth Games medals have always reflected the host city in some way. Glasgow's version does that too, but it also marks a first by making the medal itself easier to experience for every athlete who wins one.

The Feel of Victory: Nigeria's Roland Ezuruike, England's Mark Swan and Malaysia's Bonnie Bunyau Gustin pose with their medals in the men's lightweight para powerlifting game on Friday

MEDAL MAKER

The medal was designed by award-winning Militsa Milenkova, a Bulgaria-born artist in residence at the Glasgow School of Art

NON-SEQUITUR



Silk Stalkings

Reshmi Dasgupta

Twin Streams of Faith by the Ganga

Shakta and Vaishnav traditions coexist beautifully in Guptipara

The sight of dozens of bare-chested men pushing and jostling to get into a mandir should normally be cause for some alarm. Only there there were smiles and expressions of eager anticipation on the faces of the huge crowd gathered around the "Mashir Bari" (aunt's house) on the drizzly penultimate day of the Rath Yatra at Guptipara, the ancestral town of my in-laws. And once the idols of Brindavan Chandra Jiu and Krishna Chandra Jiu arrived on palanquins, the 'loot' began.

The dhoti-clad men surged forward and as the gates of the temple "treasury" symbolically gave way, they rushed in to grab the valuables. Only these were not jewels or coins but earthen pots of khichuri, the bhog prasad that Lord Jagannath and his siblings Subhadra and Balaram had been enjoying so much for the past week at their aunt's house that they did not want to return to their own home, in this case the beautiful 17th century terracotta temples at the other end of town.

Bengal is famous for its Shakta tradition, worshipping the fierce devis Kali and Durga, with rituals in some places still including animal sacrifice. However, now that UNESCO has included Durga Puja in its list of the Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity, the state has become almost synonymous with Her in popular perception. Most do not know that Bengal also has an equally strong Vaishnav tradition, from the time of Sri Chaitanya and the Bhakti movement.

So, Rath Yatras also happen in practically every neighbourhood and also in homes. At a cousin's home last week, I watched as the children of his family tugged a little rath around their courtyard, enacting a small version of the grand event at Puri. Many Bengalis, not only those living in Bengal, pull small wooden painted raths containing the images of the deities and then store them away safely till the next year. For years even I did so in our postings abroad and in Delhi.

> **Rath yatra is also the time for Bengalis to buy plants for the home, from the local melas that happen as part of the seven-day festivities**

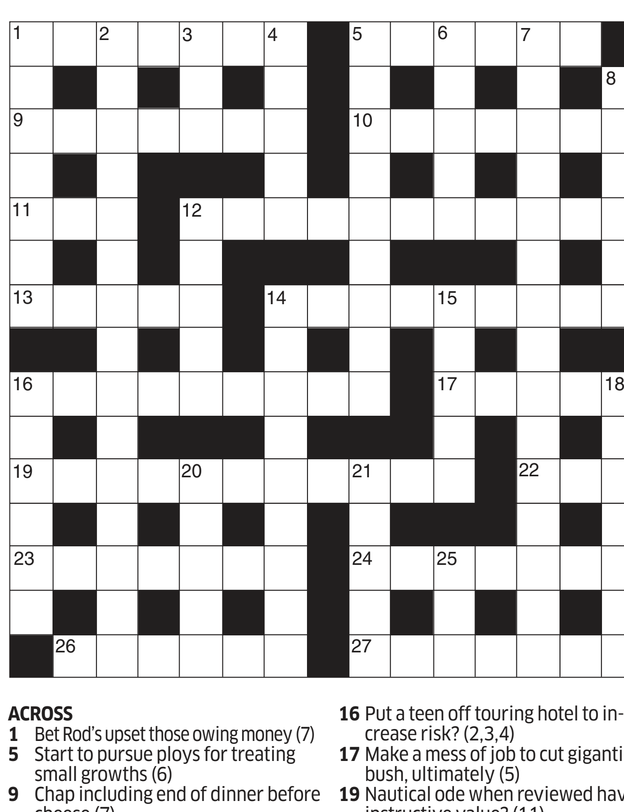
Rath yatra is also the time for Bengalis to buy plants for the home, from the local melas that happen as part of the seven-day festivities. That is presumably because monsoon is the best time to plant saplings and they also hark back to Lord Jagannath's own deep roots in nature. Over 200 types of plants and trees (wood) are used in the rituals connected with Him, so buying some saplings and seedlings for homes is a truly lovely way for lay people to connect to the Divine.

The seemingly contradictory tenets of Shakta and Vaishnavism are beautifully melded in Bengal, especially visible in Guptipara. When my in-laws' ancestors settled down on that forested and wild curve of the Ganga during the reign of Akbar, there was a primeval dasamahavidya temple. Today the "Desh Kali" (said to have been worshipped by dacoits) still stands at that spot, with no idol — just a flat surface adorned with a crown, vermilion and blood-red hibiscus flowers.

As Guptipara prospered, it became a seat of Sanskrit learning. The Sen family began their own Durga Puja soon after they built a fortified house, with a grand pavilion for her idol. The Bengali tradition of community pujas (rather than only in family homes) for Durga and Jagaddhatri also began there. Around the same time, the first terracotta Vaishnav temple, dedicated to Sri Chaitanya as an embodiment of Krishna also came up, signalling the twin streams of faith there. Three more Vaishnav ones followed in the next two centuries.

Watching those men eating the "loot" outside "Mashir Bari" as night fell, I marvelled at the seamless diversity evident in just one little town in Bengal.

Crossword 9660



ACROSS
1 Bet Rod's upset those owing money (7)
5 Start to pursue ploys for treating small growths (6)
9 Chap including end of dinner before cheese (7)
10 A part in exercise for one conditionally released (7)
11 Consume three attractive sandwiches (3)
12 Satisfactory compromise pleased channel (5,6)
13 Spanish-speaking man among these northerners (5)
14 Have a second job looming somehow by empty hut (9)
16 Put a teen off touring hotel to increase risk? (2,3,4)
17 Make a mess of job to cut gigantic bush, ultimately (5)
19 Nautical ode when reviewed having instructive value? (11)
22 Tons with gold for Greek character (3)
23 Carry out suit with muffle having spent money (7)
24 Recent rugby, maybe, needing no introduction in Welsh city (7)
26 EU capital later occupying heart of case (6)
27 American made a complaint, not good, in an excited state? (7)

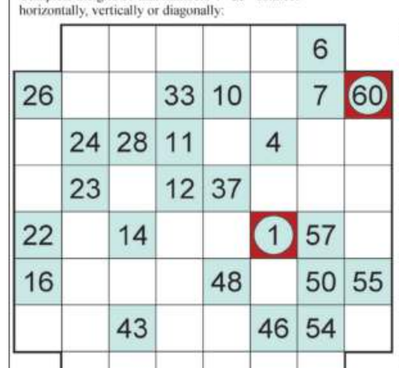
DOWN
1 Go off track in taunt about southern society (7)
2 Hammer, say, broadcast of stunt with nimble turn (5,10)
3 Precious material put in corridor, easily (3)
4 Clean with a broom range (5)
5 Infatuation when in a minority? (5,4)
6 Substantial pounds required with fancy gear (5)
7 Sites where people go to cross? (7,8)
8 First person in cast has something to hide curtain (6)
12 Some anchors exposed in bay, perhaps (5)
14 New policy in service to show virile quality (9)
15 Malign falsehood about bishop on left (5)
16 Those in blue helmets still lacking consistency (6)
18 Searched to acquire article describing a spooky place? (7)
20 A pleasing accent (5)
21 Warrior with origin in Japan, essentially (5)
25 Court in area full of trees mostly (3)

SOLUTION TO No. 9659:
ACROSS: **1** Income group. **9** Fitting. **10** Set free. **11** Hot. **12** Elegant. **13** Reasons. **14** Dai. **15** Sum up. **17** Stain. **18** Idiot. **20** Lodes. **22** Dam. **24** Bugatti. **25** Planted. **26** See. **27** Beignet. **28** Tourism. **29** Escape roads.
DOWN: **1** In the firing line. **2** Cuirass. **3** Might. **4** Gastropod. **5** Outlaws. **6** Personal details. **7** Offend. **8** Nelson. **16** Multi-step. **18** Imbibe. **19** Titanic. **21** Scapula. **23** Madams. **25** Peter.

HIDATO

FIND THE PATH - SOLVE THE PUZZLE

Complete the grid so that numbers 1 - 60 connect horizontally, vertically or diagonally:



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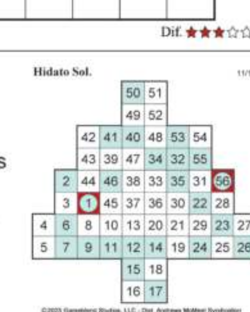
Hidato Sol. 11/11

Yesterday's puzzle solution.



7 LITTLE WORDS

Find the 7 words to match the 7 clues. The numbers in parentheses represent the number of letters in each solution. Each letter combination can be used only once, but all letter combinations will be necessary to complete the puzzle.

CLUES	SOLUTIONS
1 movement in a massage chair (9)	________
2 novelist Jenkins Reid (6)	________
3 shelled out cash (5)	________
4 looking for (9)	________
5 1970s punk rock band (7)	________
6 Silicon Valley uniform (6)	________
7 comedic actress Wiig (7)	________

ST	VIB	TI	RA	NT
AR	NES	SPE	KRI	ON
DIE	TAY	MO	RA	ING
LOR	EN	CH	SE	HOO

Yesterday's Answers: 1. RATTY 2. ELEVENTH 3. ANTLERS 4. PHYSICIANS 5. PRINCETON 6. BARGES 7. ADJECTIVES 9/5

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National & International [Genaral & Exam related]

International Newspapers

Newspapers around world. Asian, Europian & American

Hindi Newspapers

1) दैनिक जागरण
2) जनसत्ता
3) हरिभूमि
4) हिंदुस्तान

Indian Newspapers Channel

1. The Indian Express
2. The Hindu
3. Business Line
4. Financial Express
5. Times of India
6. Hindustan Times
7. Economic Times
8. Live Mint
9. Business Standard

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